Training–Rollout Mismatch in Low-Precision LLM Reinforcement Learning: A Survey

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Abstract: Low-precision rollout can accelerate generation in large language model reinforcement learning, but numerical differences between learner and sampler can alter gradient estimates and policy updates even at identical parameters. This survey develops a taxonomy based on the point of intervention in the rollout–learning loop, separating numerical design from learning under residual mismatch. Numerical design either aligns computation across the two paths or preserves numerical fidelity and the visibility of parameter updates after quantization. Learning interventions either correct gradient estimation or control the influence and acceptance of policy updates; optimization schedules complement these mechanisms. Classification applies to method components, allowing systems to combine interventions, while precision format, quantization target, and collection protocol describe their tested setting. We synthesize recent research and practice through this framework, relating disagreement measurements to estimator behavior, update decisions, and policy quality. The resulting research agenda emphasizes sustained learning over extended training, lower storage and communication overhead, and simpler adaptive control. Evaluation should test whether interventions sustain useful learning or merely postpone instability, distinguish execution error from policy staleness, and compare policy quality at matched total training cost alongside the cost of reaching a target quality.

Keywords: quantized rollout; low-precision reinforcement learning; training–inference mismatch; importance sampling; quantization-aware training.

Resources: https://github.com/ZunhaiSu/awesome-low-precision-rl

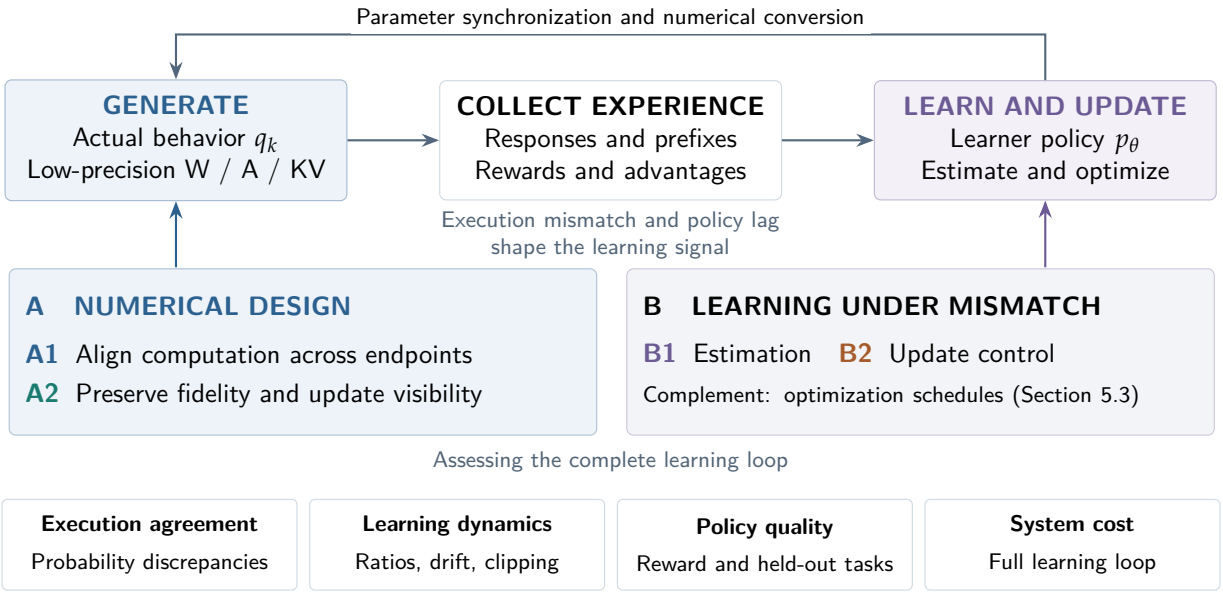


Figure 1: Survey at a glance. A changes numerical computation in the learner, sampler, or both; B corrects estimation or controls updates under residual mismatch. The two families can be combined. W, A, and KV denote weights, activations, and key–value cache.

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Reading pathways

Foundations	Methods	Evidence
Policy roles, execution mismatch, and its effects on learning.	Numerical interfaces, estimator correction, and update control.	Within-study findings, system costs, and open problems.
Sections 2–3	Sections 4–5	Sections 6–7

Appendix A: surveyed papers · Appendices B–C: sources and assumptions · Appendix D: terminology

Appendix E: mismatch measurements across core studies

1. Introduction and Scope

1.1. Why Low-Precision Rollouts Complicate Policy Optimization

In language-model reinforcement learning, generation and optimization often use different execution paths. Lower precision can reduce generation cost while changing the experience distribution. Even at identical parameters, rounding, kernels, or cached state can make learner and sampler assign different token probabilities. This discrepancy is a form of training–inference mismatch (TIM).

Probability changes affect which responses are sampled, how they are weighted, and whether their gradients survive clipping. Each update changes later parameters and rollouts, creating feedback between numerical error and learning. Early stability can conceal later deterioration.

FlashRL reweights behavior samples; Jet-RL coordinates the computations that produce their probabilities [1, 3]. These mechanisms require different information. Estimator correction can support learning under unequal policies; alignment can leave unmatched operations. Their long-term effectiveness must be assessed from the resulting learning trajectories.

Figure 2 separates numerical design (A), which changes policy computation, from learning interventions (B), which change how experience produces an update. The central question is whether their components sustain useful policy improvement at lower total cost. Appendix A maps the surveyed works to components and discussion locations.

1.2. Scope and Related Work

This survey focuses on numerical and execution mismatch in LLM reinforcement learning, especially quantized rollout and related low-precision training configurations. It covers a higher-precision learner paired with a lower-precision sampler, as well as low precision on both sides. Weight, activation, and key–value (KV) cache quantization affect different computational interfaces. Policy staleness enters where parameter changes interact with those interfaces.

The review covers nineteen core method and system studies, nine supporting formulation, theory, or general mismatch studies, and one exploration boundary case. Roles describe their use in the synthesis: MiniRL develops the formulation and also evaluates FP8 rollout [14]. Appendix B describes source selection and version handling.

Broader surveys cover low-precision training, rollout strategies, and RL for reasoning models [33–35]. Primary studies distinguish precision regimes, mismatch sources, alignment and correction, or collection and cache design [3, 6, 10, 12, 17]. Here, intervention targets organize the methods and measurement conditions organize the evidence. Adjacent quantization and rollout techniques are discussed where they explain the learner–sampler interface.

1.3. Perspective and Contributions

The taxonomy classifies what an intervention changes. Numerical design separates computation alignment from the preservation of fidelity and update visibility. Learning under residual mismatch separates gradient-estimator correction from control over update influence or acceptance. Assigning classes to components allows a system to combine mechanisms without conflating them with precision format, W/A/KV target, model architecture, or collection schedule.

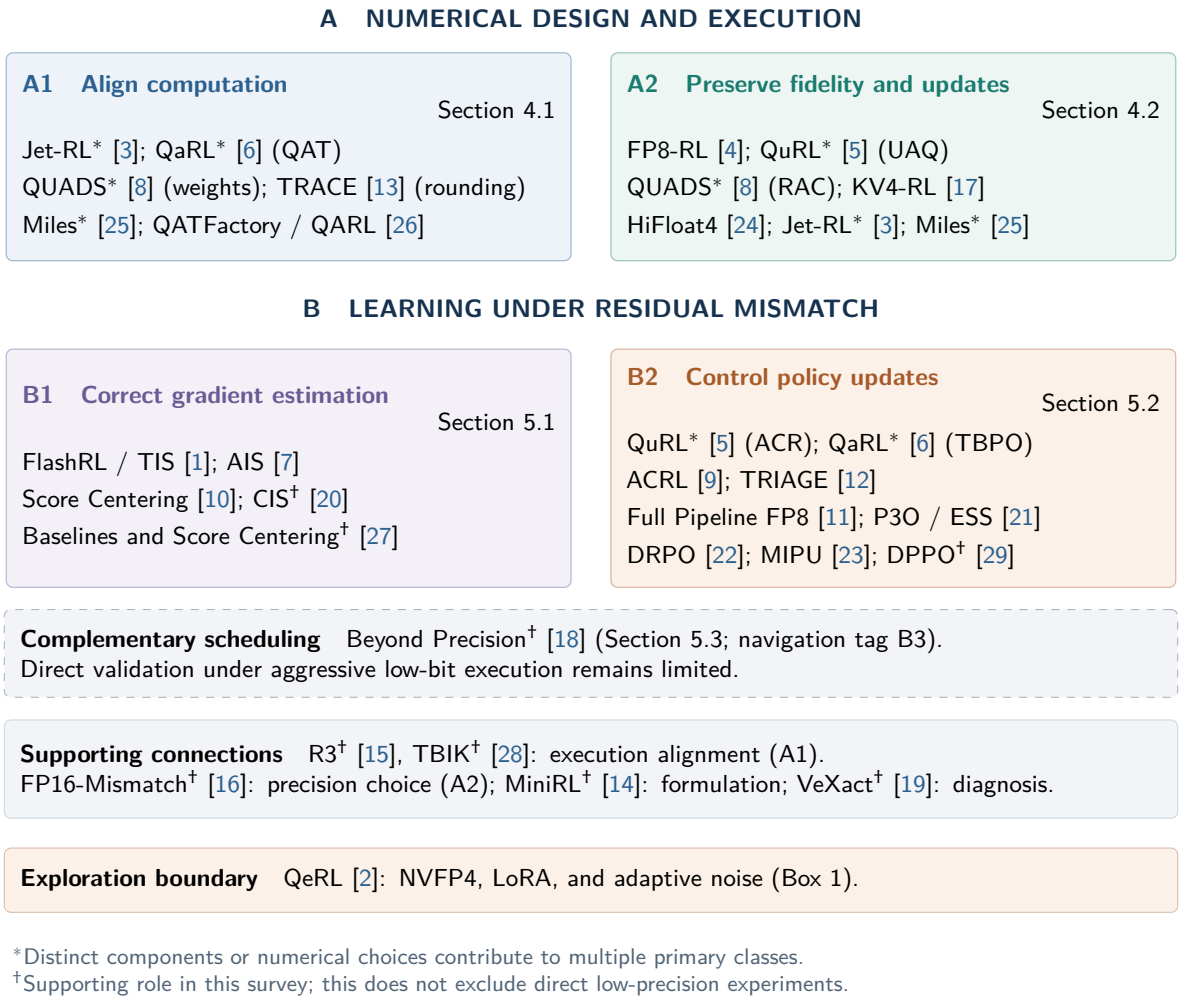


Figure 2: Component-level taxonomy of all twenty-nine focal studies. The four primary classes describe direct interventions. A work can occupy multiple classes through its components or numerical choices. Scheduling, supporting connections, and the QeRL exploration boundary are shown separately. Numerical regimes remain independent comparison axes. Appendix A gives the complete section mapping.

This framework connects method assumptions to the evidence needed to assess them. We distinguish execution paths, parameter versions, and policy roles, then interpret reported measurements through their conditioning, aggregation, and training horizon. The synthesis relates numerical disagreement to estimator reliability, update decisions, and learned quality, while separating rollout throughput from the cost of the complete learning loop.

These distinctions motivate a research agenda in sustained stability, efficient mitigation, and controlled comparison. A remedy should preserve useful learning as parameters and sampled states evolve; evidence must distinguish postponed failure from improvement maintained over the tested horizon. Lower storage, communication, and tuning costs matter alongside quality at a matched total budget and cost to a target quality. Sections 2–3 develop the formulation and mechanisms, Sections 4–5 organize interventions, and Sections 6–7 synthesize the evidence and open questions.

2. Background and Problem Formulation

2.1. Learner, Behavior, Proximal, and Reference Policies

Let x be a prompt, $y_{1:T}$ a response, and $h_t = (x, y_{<t})$ its prefix. A policy is specified by both a parameter state and the computation used to evaluate it. Write $p_\theta(a \mid h)$ for the current learner policy and $p_k(a \mid h)$ for the same learner-side path at sampling snapshot θ_k.

The behavior policy $q_k(a \mid h)$ is the distribution that actually sampled the token. It includes the rollout engine, numerical representation, and sampling transformation. Temperature and vocabulary truncation therefore belong to its definition: a raw-model log-probability returned by an engine need not equal the probability after decoding transformations.

The proximal policy p_{prox} defines the update ratio; the reference policy p_{ref} defines the regularization target. A frozen pre-update learner may supply the proximal policy, and an earlier checkpoint the KL reference. Neither necessarily generated the tokens. PPO and GRPO use these roles [30, 31]; mismatch-aware formulations explicitly distinguish them from behavior [1, 14].

A running GRPO update. Consider a prompt for which the sampler generates G responses. A task-dependent scorer assigns reward R_i to response i; in RL with verifiable rewards, a correctness checker can supply this score without a learned reward model. A common group-relative advantage is $A_i = (R_i - \bar{R})/(\sigma_R + \epsilon_A)$, where $\bar{R}$ and σ_R are the group mean and standard deviation, and $\epsilon_A > 0$ stabilizes the normalization. For binary rewards $(1, 1, 0, 0)$, the advantages are approximately $(1, 1, -1, -1)$. The advantage is held fixed during optimization and is typically shared by the valid tokens of the response. Some variants omit standard-deviation normalization [31].

At the learning stage, a representative clipped objective on this fixed group is

$$\begin{aligned} \widehat{J}(\theta) &= \frac{1}{G}\sum_{i=1}^{G}\frac{1}{T_i}\sum_{t=1}^{T_i}\left[\ell(r_{i,t}, A_i) - \beta \mathcal{K}_{i,t}(\theta)\right], \\ \ell(r, A) &= \min\{rA, \text{clip}(r, 1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon)A\}. \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

where T_i counts valid response tokens, $r_{i,t} = p_\theta(y_{i,t} \mid h_{i,t})/p_{\text{prox}}(y_{i,t} \mid h_{i,t})$, ϵ sets the clipping interval, and β controls optional reference regularization. Here $\mathcal{K}_{i,t} = D_{\text{KL}}(p_\theta(\cdot \mid h_{i,t}) \| p_{\text{ref}}(\cdot \mid h_{i,t}))$ denotes the conditional KL; implementations can instead use sampled estimators. Maximizing the surrogate encourages positive-advantage actions and discourages negative-advantage actions. Clipping limits incentives for large changes relative to the proximal policy; reference KL provides a separate anchor.

After the update, weights are synchronized and converted for the next rollout. With matched execution and decoding, the pre-update learner can also be the behavior policy: $q = p_{\text{prox}}$. Quantized rollout breaks this identification even before an update. At $p_\theta = p_{\text{prox}}$, the proximal ratio is one, but p_{prox}/q can already differ from one. Section 5.1 shows how an explicit behavior correction can be separated from the update ratio. Numerical design acts on these computations, estimator correction on the sampled experience, and update control on the learning step.

MIPU targets improvement in the inference policy obtained after conversion and synchronization, since it supplies the next experience [23].

Table 1: Policies and quantities used throughout the survey. Execution paths are part of policy identity.

Symbol	Meaning
p_θ	Current learner policy under its specified execution path.
p_k	Learner-side policy evaluated at sampling snapshot θ_k.
q_k	Actual behavior policy that sampled the token.
p_{prox}	Policy used to define the proximal update ratio.
p_{ref}	Policy used for KL regularization; not the behavior denominator.
Δ_k	Same-snapshot log-probability difference, $\log p_k - \log q_k$.
d_θ	Current learner–behavior gap, $\log p_\theta - \log q_k$.
A_t	Advantage or other policy-gradient learning signal.
$s_\theta(a,h)$	Score vector, $\nabla_\theta \log p_\theta(a \mid h)$.
$c_t, \bar{c}_t$	Behavior-to-proximal correction and its truncated or masked form.
$r_t(\theta)$	Proximal update ratio, $p_\theta / p_{\text{prox}}$.
$W_\theta(y \mid x)$	Complete-response likelihood ratio, P_θ / Q.
N, sg	Valid-token count and stop-gradient operator in Equation (10).

2.2. Execution Mismatch versus Policy Staleness

At a fixed prefix and token with positive relevant probabilities,

$$\frac{p_\theta(a \mid h)}{q_k(a \mid h)} = \underbrace{\left(\frac{p_\theta(a \mid h)}{p_k(a \mid h)}\right)}_{\text{parameter change / lag}} \times \underbrace{\left(\frac{p_k(a \mid h)}{q_k(a \mid h)}\right)}_{\substack{\text{same-snapshot} \\ \text{execution / decoding}}}. \tag{2}$$

The first factor captures parameter change since collection, including asynchronous version lag; the factorization requires no independence assumption. The second compares execution at the sampling snapshot. It isolates numerical differences when decoding is matched and also includes decoding differences when temperature or top-p filtering changes. The intermediate policy p_k is a conceptual reference and need not be retained by the implementation. In partial rollout, a response can span collection boundaries, so $k = k(t)$ may vary across tokens. If caches survive synchronization, retained entries encode earlier computations. Their provenance records the versions and numerical paths that produced them; a current checkpoint identifier alone does not specify this behavior state. The notation q_k abbreviates that stateful rollout path.

Figure 3 separates these snapshot comparisons from the two policy roles used by the loss. A proximal anchor and a KL reference can be chosen independently of the actual sampler.

At the sampling snapshot, the parameter-change factor is one, yet execution mismatch can remain. Conversely, matched execution and decoding make the second factor one without removing policy lag. Numerical alignment and staleness correction address different factors of the same ratio.

Importance ratios require the behavior policy to assign positive probability wherever the target does. Vocabulary truncation can violate this support condition even though every observed token has a defined denominator. At fixed h,

$$\mathbb{E}_{a \sim q_k(\cdot \mid h)}\left[\frac{p_\theta(a \mid h)}{q_k(a \mid h)} f(a,h)\right] = \mathbb{E}_{a \sim p_\theta(\cdot \mid h)}[f(a,h)] \tag{3}$$

holds under support and integrability assumptions. It corrects the action distribution at a fixed prefix while leaving the distribution over prefixes unchanged.

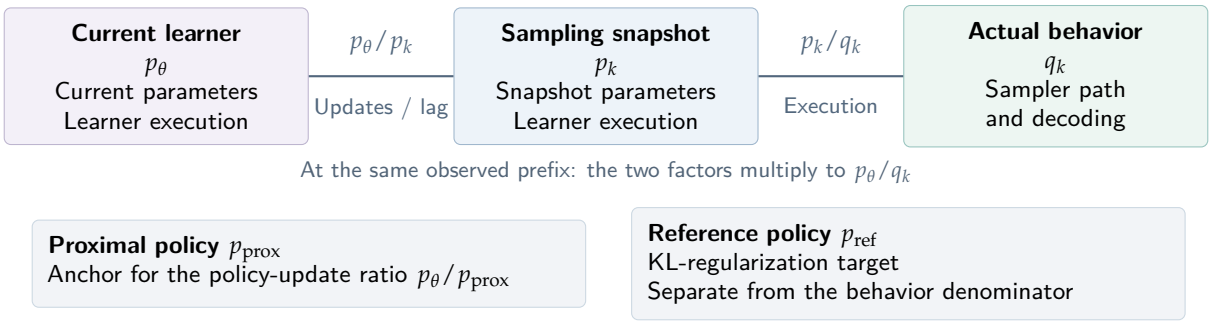


Figure 3: Policy identities and loss roles. Horizontal links denote the ratio comparisons in Equation (2), rather than data flow. Execution differences isolate numerical mismatch when decoding is matched. The lower cards identify separate roles in optimization.

The sampler can therefore visit histories with different frequencies from the target policy. Figure 13 illustrates this distinction, and Appendix C gives the full-response identities. In group-relative RL, changing the response distribution also changes the groups used to compute advantages [10].

2.3. A Component-Level Taxonomy of Interventions

We classify components by their *intervention target*: the computation or learning rule they change. The *source* of mismatch explains why probabilities differ; the *experimental setting* specifies precision, adaptation, and collection. Neither alone determines the method class.

A: numerical design intervenes in the computations that produce mismatch. A1 aligns learner and sampler execution; A2 preserves numerical information and the parameter updates that quantization can obscure. These components can act on the learner, the sampler, or both. **B: learning under residual mismatch** intervenes in how disagreement affects learning from collected samples. B1 corrects gradient estimation; B2 constrains, selects, or accepts policy updates. B can preserve useful learning without reducing the policy gap (Table 2).

Classification follows a component's purpose. Both B1 and B2 can weight a loss: B1 derives a correction from a target expectation, whereas B2 constrains or selects updates. Truncation can bias a B1 estimator, and B2 controls can also change estimation. An importance ratio alone therefore does not determine the class. DPPO and DRPO contribute B2 trust-region geometry; Score Centering contributes B1 correction of a conditional score expectation [10, 22, 29].

Several systems combine classes. QaRL pairs aligned QAT (A1) with TBPO (B2); QuRL pairs update-aware quantization (A2) with adaptive clipping (B2); QUADS pairs weight alignment (A1) with activation compensation (A2) [5, 6, 8]. Adopted corrections such as TIS are distinguished from each system's contribution. Scheduling complements these classes (B3).

Table 2: Intervention targets and decision questions. Figure 2 maps their associated studies.

Class	Decision question	What changes	Key dependency
A1	Can the two execution paths agree more closely?	Operators, representations, or realized numerical decisions.	Correspondence between computations.
A2	Is useful information preserved at low precision?	Scales, residuals, update resolution, or protected states.	Identification of sensitive information.
B1	How should behavior samples estimate a target gradient?	Importance weights or conditional score expectations.	Target distribution and available behavior information.
B2	Which updates should influence the next policy?	Constraints, contribution weights, or candidate acceptance.	Learning signal and control criterion.
B3	When and how strongly should learning proceed?	Complementary optimization schedule.	A signal for adaptation over time.

2.4. Numerical Regimes and Contribution Roles

Quantization maps values to a discrete set using a specified format, scale, and rounding rule. Weight quantization changes parameters that can be shared within a sampling version. Activation quantization acts on values recomputed during each forward pass. KV quantization acts on attention state retained across token positions. These targets differ in when their errors arise and how long those errors remain in the computation.

Post-training quantization converts a learned model without adaptation through the target quantizer. Quantization-aware training (QAT) models quantization during learning. Fake quantization quantizes and dequantizes operands while matrix multiplications can remain at higher precision; a straight-through estimator supplies surrogate derivatives through rounding, as in QUADS [8]. Native kernels perform the specified low-precision arithmetic directly. QAT specifies adaptation; speed and backward, master-weight, and optimizer precision must be reported separately.

QuRL adapts to quantized rollout without an explicit learner-side QAT path: the sampler is repeatedly quantized while a higher-precision learner trains on its experience [5]. Low-rank or full-parameter updates, native or simulated arithmetic, architecture, and collection protocol specify the setting independently of the intervention target.

3. How Execution Mismatch Affects Learning

3.1. Sources and Propagation of Execution Discrepancy

Scales, rounding, accumulation, kernels, batch shape, and cached state can alter probabilities at the same nominal precision. FP16-based analysis examines precision selection [16]; R3 isolates routing differences that can occur without quantization [15].

Reduction order can change even when precision is fixed. TBIK coordinates reduction trees across tensor-parallel sizes, providing a matched-execution reference [28]. Under low precision, HiFloat4's ablations link degraded learning to outlier-driven underflow in rollout activations [24].

Shared-prefix probes compare conditional policies on fixed histories. Free-running comparisons also capture changed trajectories, where small errors can redirect generation.

Quantization can hide an update within one cell or amplify a small change across a boundary. QuRL seeks to make updates visible to the sampler; TRACE reduces inconsistent rounding [5, 13]. Both effects depend on the values' positions relative to quantization boundaries.

Backward arithmetic can change an update even when forward policies agree. Jet-RL specifies backward precision, and Miles offers a dequantized backward path to protect gradient fidelity [3, 25]. Interpreting low-precision failures therefore requires both policy-gap diagnostics and the learner's derivative computation.

Figure 4 shows how discrepancy changes sample influence, induces score drift, and alters update selection. An aggregate gap does not distinguish these mechanisms.

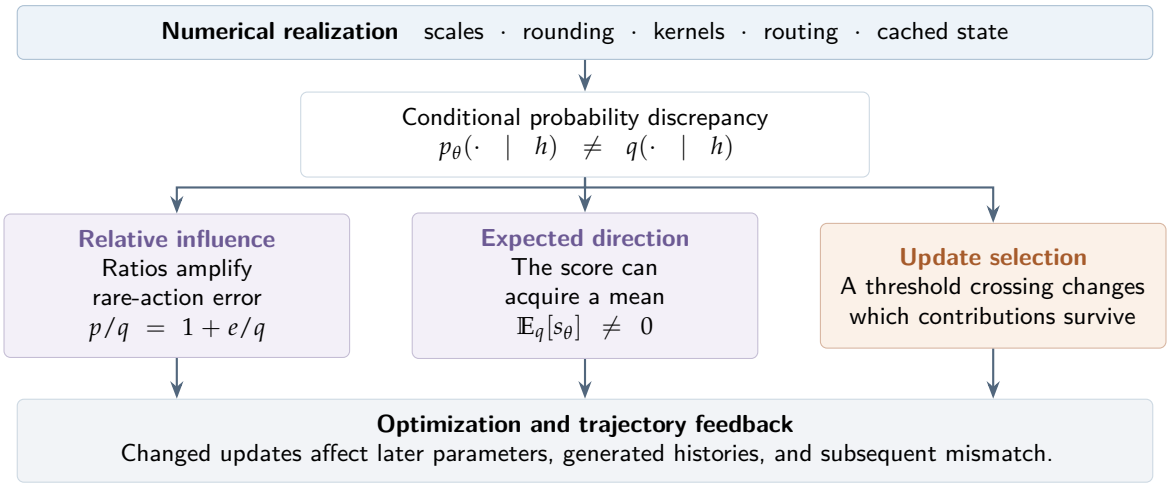


Figure 4: Three routes from execution discrepancy to learning: relative influence [1], expected score direction [10], and update selection [11, 12]. These effects can coexist and feed back through later updates and generated histories. Arrows denote propagation under the stated policy and estimator assumptions.

3.2. Distorted Estimation and Update Decisions

At an observed prefix, numerical disagreement can change an update through its weight, its expected direction, or the clipping branch it activates. Absolute probability error captures only part of this effect. Writing $p = q + e$ gives $p/q = 1 + e/q$: the same absolute perturbation has greater relative influence when q is small. Tails and confidence-conditioned statistics therefore reveal structure that a mean absolute error can hide. CIS uses this confidence dependence in its correction design [20].

DPPO distinguishes relative ratios from moved probability mass [29]. A large ratio on a rare token can move little mass, while a moderate ratio on a common token can move much more. Ratio magnitude alone does not specify an appropriate update constraint.

Estimation can also acquire a systematic drift. For a normalized differentiable learner distribution, $\mathbb{E}_{a\sim p_\theta}[s_\theta(a,h)] = 0$. Under behavior sampling, the corresponding expectation need not vanish. At fixed h,

$$\mathbb{E}_q[As_\theta] = \mathrm{Cov}_q(A, s_\theta) + \mathbb{E}_q[A]\mathbb{E}_q[s_\theta]. \tag{4}$$

The expectations are conditional on the prefix and include the sampled action and any random continuation used to form A. Centering advantages across a prompt group need not center them at each prefix. Score Centering uses this distinction to motivate an additive correction [10]: it removes a first-moment drift term while leaving the behavior distribution itself unchanged.

Mismatch additionally affects decisions made by a surrogate objective. In a clipped policy-gradient objective, changing a ratio can change which branch is active and therefore whether a token contributes gradient. Thus, a perturbation can matter through a threshold crossing even when its absolute magnitude appears modest. The full-pipeline FP8 study isolates a failure involving excessive clipping of negative-advantage tokens [11]. This is a different intervention target from merely decreasing the variance of a sampled importance weight.

The sign dependence can be seen without assuming a particular quantizer. Let $\ell(r, A) = \min\{rA, \mathrm{clip}(r, 1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon)A\}$, with $0 < \epsilon < 1$ and fixed A. Away from the two boundaries,

$$\frac{\partial \ell}{\partial r} = \begin{cases} A\,\mathbf{1}\{r < 1+\epsilon\}, & A > 0, \\ A\,\mathbf{1}\{r > 1-\epsilon\}, & A < 0, \\ 0, & A = 0. \end{cases} \tag{5}$$

Clipping depends on the advantage sign and the ratio being clipped. If the objective clips the combined learner–behavior ratio, $r = 0.7$ with $\epsilon = 0.2$ suppresses a negative-advantage token even at the sampling snapshot. This illustrates a different objective from the decoupled surrogate in Section 5.1.

Figure 5 illustrates the advantage-dependent clipping branches.

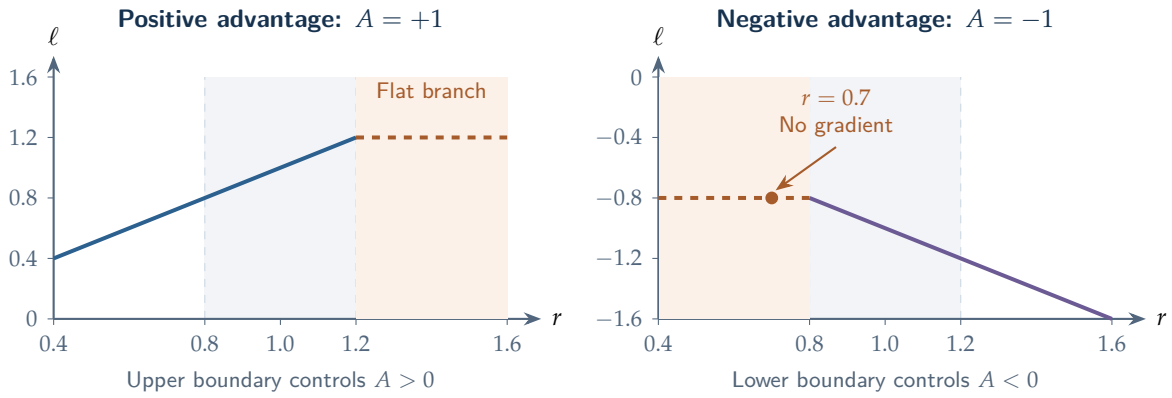


Figure 5: Signed clipping in Equation (5), with $\epsilon = 0.2$ and $A = \pm 1$. The gray interval is $[0.8, 1.2]$; amber segments are flat. At $r = 0.7$, a negative-advantage token contributes no gradient through this objective. Constructed example of the PPO surrogate with the specified ratio [30].

3.3. Feedback across Optimization Steps

A discrepancy measured on one batch evolves as learning proceeds. Sampled responses drive the learner update; synchronization converts it into the next sampler; the new sampler changes later responses. A small frozen-batch error does not establish stability under this feedback.

The direction of an update matters as well as the gap's magnitude. Locally, reducing a learner probability already below the behavior probability can enlarge the log gap. ACRL and TRIAGE use directional information to control updates [9, 12]. In a shared-parameter network, one token's gradient also changes other probabilities, so this local sign argument alone cannot guarantee stability.

The learning rate also affects this feedback. Beyond Precision proposes response-length-triggered decay based on the relationship between mismatch and optimization dynamics [18]. Its effectiveness under aggressive FP4 execution remains to be established.

3.4. Diagnosing and Measuring Mismatch

Studies measure computational disagreement, estimator reliability, update decisions, and learning outcomes (Table 3). Each answers a different question. Interpretation requires the compared policies, conditioning, and aggregation, recorded for all nineteen core studies in Appendix E.

Policy comparison and conditioning. A *controlled numerical probe* fixes parameters and prefixes to compare execution paths. An *online diagnostic* compares the current learner with recorded behavior and may include policy lag (Equation (2)). Figure 6 contrasts the two. Raw, decoded, and recomputed probabilities remain distinct; VeXact supplies a matched-execution reference [19].

KV4-RL computes full-vocabulary $D_{\mathrm{KL}}(p_{\mathrm{BF16}} \| q_{\mathrm{quant}})$ at identical BF16-generated prefixes from the same checkpoint, before temperature or truncation [17]. The probe isolates conditional KV distortion and excludes trajectory selection. Conditioning also differs within TRIAGE: its 30B characterization replays sampled MoE routes, whereas its 4B run measures the ordinary learner–sampler gap. Their raw magnitudes are therefore not directly comparable [12].

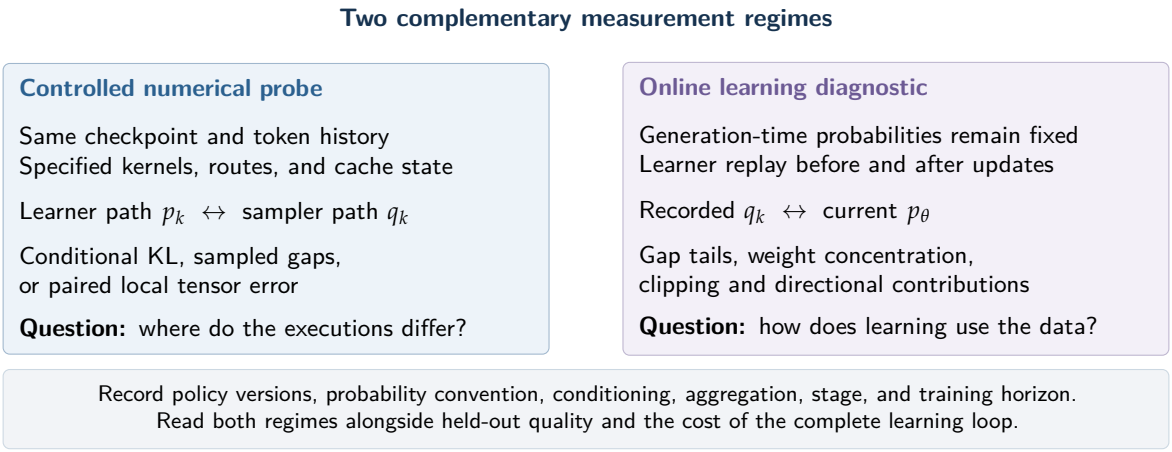


Figure 6: Controlled probes and online diagnostics target different comparisons [12, 17, 20]. Execution attribution depends on the factors held fixed; online gaps can include policy lag.

Probability gaps and KL answer different questions. For a specified pair of normalized conditional policies p, q, let $d_t = \log p(a_t \mid h_t) - \log q(a_t \mid h_t)$ on sampled actions $a_t \sim q(\cdot \mid h_t)$. Common summaries include

$$G_{\mathrm{abs}} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_t |d_t|, \qquad \widehat{K}_1 = -\frac{1}{N}\sum_t d_t, \qquad \widehat{K}_3 = \frac{1}{N}\sum_t \left(e^{d_t} - d_t - 1\right). \tag{6}$$

Here N counts valid measured tokens, and G_{abs} removes the gap's sign. With common support and finite expectations, both KL estimators target conditional $D_{\mathrm{KL}}(q\|p)$ averaged over the observed prefixes. In finite samples, $\widehat{K}_1$ can be negative, while every $\widehat{K}_3$ summand is nonnegative. These sampled estimates differ from reverse-direction $D_{\mathrm{KL}}(p\|q)$, full-vocabulary evaluation, and KL to a regularization reference.

TRIAGE and AIS report mean absolute log gaps; TRACE reports maxima and minima; QUADS tracks a maximum gap; QuRL reports behavior-to-proximal KL and a maximum ratio; MIPU uses

sampled-token K3 [5, 7, 8, 12, 13, 23]. Extremes can expose errors hidden by a mean, but also depend on population size and composition. Their magnitudes are comparable only under matched definitions, populations, and reductions.

Table 3: Complementary levels of mismatch diagnosis. Each level answers a different question; outcomes require evidence connecting them to the preceding mechanisms.

Question	Representative measurements	Interpretation boundary
Where do computations disagree?	Shared-prefix KL; sampled-action gaps and tails; paired activation error [8, 12, 13, 17].	Specify checkpoint, prefix, routing, probability convention, and tensor location.
How reliable is the estimator?	Raw or capped weight concentration; ESS; conditional score mean; variance amplification [7, 10, 21].	Concentration and drift are different effects. A theoretical estimand is not automatically a logged statistic.
Which updates change?	Sign-separated clipping; directional mass and segment localization; candidate acceptance [11, 12, 23].	Requires the objective, fixed advantages, and the relevant update or synchronization stage.
Does learning remain useful?	Reward, held-out quality, entropy, failure time, and total cost.	Training outcomes assess consequences; they do not uniquely identify numerical mismatch.

Estimator and update diagnostics. Normalized empirical effective sample size (ESS) summarizes weight concentration:

$$\mathrm{ESS}_{\mathrm{norm}}(w) = \frac{(\sum_t w_t)^2}{N \sum_t w_t^2}. \tag{7}$$

P3O computes ESS from raw current-to-behavior ratios; AIS uses truncated weights [7, 21]. The values can therefore differ on identical data. Uniform nonzero weights give normalized ESS one regardless of their common value, so high ESS establishes neither calibration nor gradient fidelity. Score Centering addresses the conditional score mean instead (Section 5.1) [10].

The full-pipeline FP8 study uses BF16 shadow passes to identify tokens whose active clipping branch changes under FP8, separating the two advantage signs [11]. This counterfactual *over-clipping* is not an ordinary clipping fraction. TRIAGE measures directional mass and local concentration from signed gaps, then tests the indicator against realized updates [12]. These diagnostics assess how discrepancy changes an update; legitimate learning can still increase disagreement.

Measurement population and aggregation. Token and response averages assign different weights to the data. Masking can lower a reported gap by excluding difficult cases; capping can raise ESS by reducing weight concentration. Comparisons must therefore specify the measured population and whether the statistic precedes or follows the intervention, alongside the policy and probability conventions (Appendix E).

Training duration and delayed instability. Longer optimization and longer generated trajectories test different properties. To assess persistence across updates, report optimizer steps, rollout and learner tokens, and elapsed training cost, and retain late-stage measurements alongside the best checkpoint. Periodic paired probes separate execution error from parameter lag; online diagnostics and held-out quality track its learning consequences.

Time to failure requires a declared event and persistence window, such as a sustained quality loss assessed alongside estimator or update diagnostics. Independent training runs expose variation in its onset. A run that ends without the event bounds the observation window; it does not establish an unlimited failure time. Longer runs should also track retained learning contributions, since a controller can suppress instability by progressively suppressing learning.

A useful diagnostic connects a specified discrepancy to an estimator or update effect and tests its consequences for learning quality over a stated horizon and cost. Minimizing every online gap would also penalize legitimate policy movement.

Box 1. Quantization and exploration

QeRL combines low-precision execution, low-rank adaptation, and adaptive quantization noise, making exploration an explicit part of the training design [2]. It occupies a boundary of this survey: the numerical perturbation changes the search process as well as agreement between computations. The reported benefit concerns structured quantization noise under low-rank adaptation and depends on the induced sampling distribution and the learner's adaptation capacity.

The following sections examine remedies in the computations that produce disagreement (Section 4) and in the learning rules that use the resulting experience (Section 5).

4. Numerical Design and Execution Alignment

Numerical design can act on the learner, the sampler, or the interface between them. Alignment brings their computations closer at a shared interface; fidelity control preserves information that a low-precision representation would otherwise lose. The distinction matters because two approximate paths can agree without either becoming more accurate relative to a higher-precision model.

4.1. Aligning Learner and Rollout Computation

Jet-RL coordinates precision across the training and rollout computation graphs [3]. Corresponding forward operators share precision and quantization granularity. Linear-layer forward and backward GEMMs use FP8 inputs, while gradients transported between operators remain BF16. This precision flow extends beyond learner-side fake quantization.

QaRL couples rollout-aligned learner QAT (A1) with TBPO (B2) [6]. QAT brings the learner forward closer to the quantized rollout representation; TBPO controls sequence-level updates when low-bit generation produces problematic responses.

QUADS treats weights and activations differently [8]. Synchronized weights can share a quantize–dequantize path, whereas activations are recomputed from engine-dependent inputs. The same coarse quantizer can then send nearby values to different codewords. QUADS fake-quantizes learner weights, retains BF16 learner activations, and compensates selected rollout activation errors. Its asymmetric-versus-symmetric ablation shows that quantizing the same operands on both sides need not improve agreement. Section 4.2 examines the activation compensation.

Matching a quantizer still leaves the rounding outcome dependent on its input. TRACE aligns realized rounding decisions [13]. A shared FP4 format and scale can still send nearby learner and rollout activations to different codewords. TRACE records rollout-side quantization information and uses it to guide the learner's corresponding quantization site. With exact guidance and fixed rollout

scales, it selects from the learner value's two neighboring codewords the one nearest the rollout codeword. Figure 7 illustrates why this can reduce cross-path discrepancy even when it slightly increases the learner's own quantization error.

The practical mechanism approximates this reference with compact code information. By default, TRACE caches one low code bit and the scales from the latter half of the layers, pairing records by trajectory, token position, and quantization site. The reconstruction uses the current learner activation as side information: after normalization by the rollout scale, it selects the nearest E2M1 magnitude whose retained code bits match the record, taking the sign from the learner. The adjacent learner candidates are then compared with this reference. Thus, the record narrows a local choice; it does not independently recover an arbitrary rollout value. Earlier layers can still be quantized without retaining this guidance. Reconstruction reliability consequently depends on the observed local adjacency of paired activations.

TRACE's main rollout quantizes expert W/A and softmax-layer KV to NVFP4, retaining BF16 elsewhere. The learner uses guided fake quantization at matching sites, with BF16 matrix multiplication, attention, and backward computation. Routing replay and token-level correction address residual differences; unpaired sites and policy lag remain sources of error [13].

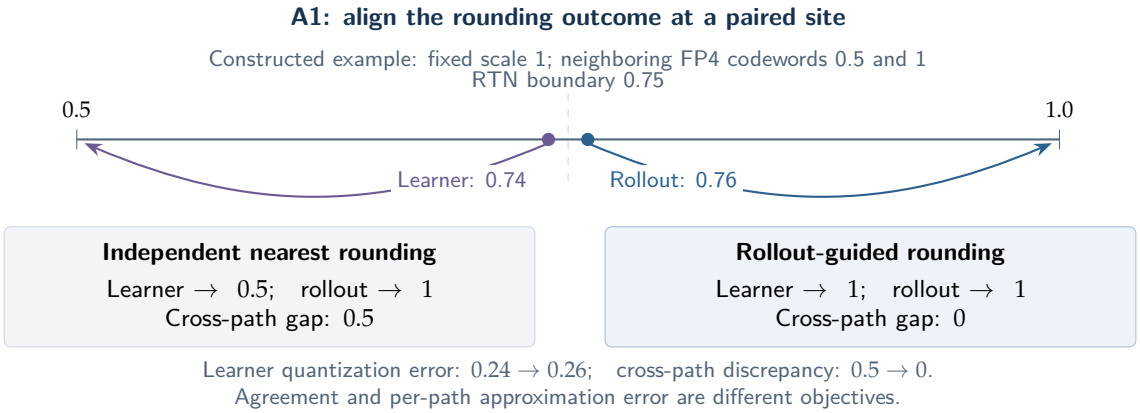


Figure 7: Rollout-guided rounding in a constructed fixed-scale E2M1 example. Agreement improves while learner approximation error increases slightly. Exact guidance applies at the paired site; TRACE's compact implementation approximates the reference [13].

Alignment must survive conversion and synchronization. Miles coordinates checkpoint conversion, learner forward, rollout kernels, and live export using shared quantization rules; its MXFP8 and NVFP4 recipes include precision exceptions and are marked Beta [25]. QATFactory's QARL trains with BF16 quantization simulation, uses native NVFP4 rollout, and exports low-bit weights [26].

Jet-RL shares numerical configuration, aligned QAT shares representations, and TRACE shares rollout-specific decisions. Routing replay matches MoE choices [15]; TBIK matches reduction order [28]. Each requires matched tokens, modules, and parameter versions at the relevant computation; unmatched operations can still differ.

4.2. Controlling Quantization Error and Preserving Parameter Updates

Alignment alone does not ensure that the sampler can express the changes made by training. For an illustrative deterministic quantizer Q, an update can satisfy

$$Q(w + \delta w) = Q(w), \tag{8}$$

even when $\delta w \neq 0$. Visibility depends on update magnitude, distance to a quantization boundary, and scale behavior. QuRL's Update-Aware Quantization applies a one-time invariant rescaling before RL [5]. The identity $WX = (W/s)(sX)$ preserves the initial real-valued layer output while changing the magnitudes seen by quantization and optimization. Rescaling is chosen to improve update size relative to quantization noise. Reparameterization changes gradients and can alter later optimization. UAQ targets sampler update visibility; ACR controls the learner's clipping region (Section 5.2).

Figure 8 shows a smaller update crossing a boundary while a larger one stays within its cell. Changing the scale moves these boundaries.

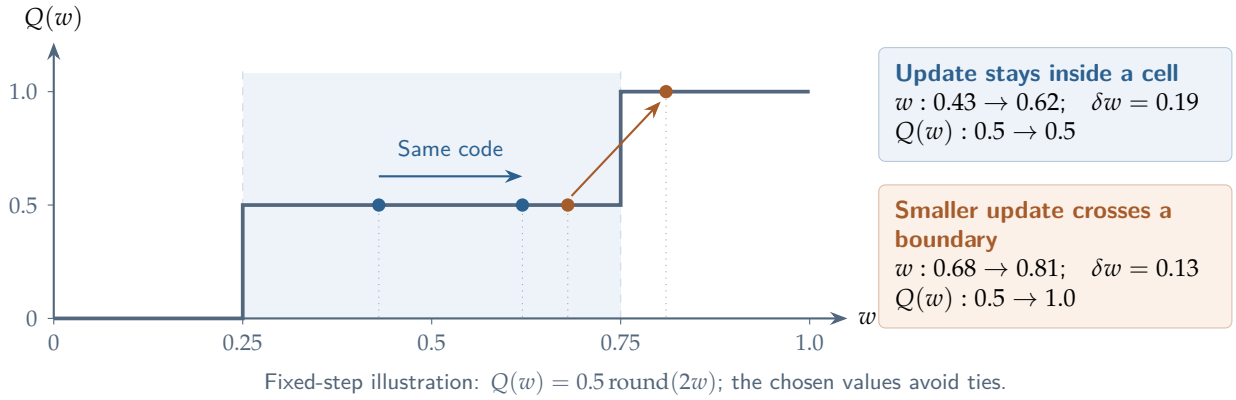


Figure 8: Constructed illustration of update visibility (Equation (8)). The blue update stays inside a quantization cell while the smaller amber update crosses a boundary. Changing scales moves the boundaries.

QUADS addresses residual activation error after learner-side weight alignment. Residual Activation Compensation restores selected high-error channels around native W4A4 rollout computation [8]. Weight QAT changes the shared weight representation; compensation changes the rollout activation approximation. Ablations isolate the gains of the two components.

HiFloat4 / Rollout-ResQ corrects rollout activation underflow with sparse residuals [24]. Its learner–sampler precision comparisons isolate an error that raising learner precision alone does not resolve. These FP4 experiments simulate the arithmetic and do not measure native-FP4 acceleration.

FP8-RL maintains numerical fidelity as the policy changes through blockwise W8A8 rollout, scale recalibration for FP8 attention and KV execution, and dynamic weight synchronization [4]. It integrates these components with adopted TIS/MIS correction. Its v2 experiments also explore end-to-end FP8, so learner precision varies across the paper's experimental settings.

Miles retains selected tensors in BF16 and offers an optional dequantized backward path that trades training throughput for gradient stability without changing the quantized forward values [25]. These choices specify the fidelity of its forward and derivative computations separately.

KV4-RL uses INT4 KV with bounded INT8 protection for attention-sink and recent positions [17]. TIS remains fixed across cache-precision comparisons, isolating the benefit of changing the sampler

computation. In colocated, quota-based partial collection, generation and optimization alternate; responses can span collection boundaries.

Rescaling preserves update resolution; compensation reduces activation error; recalibration follows distributional change; positional protection preserves sensitive cache states. Such scaling, rotation, and residual-correction techniques [24] must also accommodate a policy whose parameters and sampled activations change during RL.

4.3. Residual Mismatch and Limits of Alignment

A shared quantizer can coexist with different activations or surrounding kernels. Alignment is therefore defined at a specified interface, snapshot, and history; fidelity separately concerns approximation to a higher-precision computation.

Even a numerically faithful sampler may lag behind the learner. Agreement at observed prefixes also leaves intact the history distribution changed by earlier sampling decisions. Learning-side corrections and controls address the effects of these residual differences on estimation and updates.

Maintaining a shared numerical interface requires information as well as arithmetic. Operator choices require coordination, QAT depends on matching quantizer semantics, and rounding guidance requires storage and correspondence with learner states [3, 6, 8, 13]. Fidelity control instead uses calibration, compensation, or selective execution to preserve sensitive information [4, 5, 17]. Table 4 compares these dependencies and the discrepancies each leaves unresolved.

Table 4: Numerical strategies: shared information, execution dependencies, and residual differences.

Strategy	Shared or protected object	Information dependency	Residual discrepancy
Precision flow	Corresponding operator precision and granularity	Coordinated numerical configuration	Engine and surrounding-kernel differences.
Aligned QAT	Learner representation corresponding to rollout	Matching quantizer semantics	Native versus simulated arithmetic; unmatched activations.
Guided rounding	Realized rollout quantization decisions	Stored and matched rollout guidance	Unshared modules and downstream propagation.
Fidelity control	Scales, update resolution, residuals, or protected states	Calibration, compensation, or selective execution	Other execution paths and policy staleness.

5. Learning under Residual Mismatch

Learning methods address the experience already collected. Estimator correction changes how behavior samples estimate a target gradient; update control restricts their influence on the next policy. Scheduling adjusts the scale of successive updates. These choices affect estimation bias and variance as well as learning progress and stability.

5.1. Correcting Gradient Estimation

Multiplicative correction and truncation. Equation (3) gives the conditional change of measure. A decoupled surrogate separates behavior correction from the proximal update ratio. For a frozen proximal policy p_{prox} and recorded behavior q, define

$$c_t = \frac{p_{\text{prox}}(a_t \mid h_t)}{q(a_t \mid h_t)}, \qquad r_t(\theta) = \frac{p_\theta(a_t \mid h_t)}{p_{\text{prox}}(a_t \mid h_t)}. \tag{9}$$

A representative decoupled surrogate is

$$\widehat{L}(\theta) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_t \text{sg}(\bar{c}_t) \min[r_t(\theta)A_t, \text{clip}(r_t(\theta), 1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon)A_t], \tag{10}$$

where $\bar{c}_t$ is a possibly truncated correction, advantages are held fixed, N counts valid sampled tokens, and sg prevents differentiation through the correction weight. Before truncation and clipping, $c_t r_t = p_\theta / q$ compares the current learner with the actual sampler. Bounding c_t limits collection-related correction; clipping r_t limits the incentive for policy change during the update. Upper truncation uses $\bar{c}_t = \min(c_t, C)$, whereas masking discards selected ratios. Response-level averaging and length normalization assign different relative weights, making the reduction rule part of the estimator.

FlashRL uses actual rollout probabilities for truncated importance sampling (TIS) [1]. MiniRL distinguishes behavior and proximal policies [14]. FP8-RL adopts token-level TIS and masked importance sampling (MIS), while KV4-RL retains TIS alongside cache protection [4, 17]. Truncation bounds influence but introduces bias.

Adapting the amount and location of correction. Adaptive importance sampling (AIS) makes correction strength depend on both necessity and reliability [7]. Its effective multiplier has the form $1 + \alpha(\bar{w} - 1)$: $\alpha = 0$ retains the uncorrected estimator, while $\alpha = 1$ applies the truncated importance weight $\bar{w}$. A mean absolute log gap indicates whether correction is needed; capped-weight ESS and advantage-weight variance amplification indicate whether it is reliable. A large mismatch can therefore coexist with weak correction when the weighted estimator is too concentrated or noisy. AIS adapts an estimator mixture rather than the precision or clipping threshold.

Calibrated importance sampling (CIS) adjusts the truncation cap according to confidence. It represents cross-engine perturbation as a log-odds displacement, which can produce very different ratios for low- and high-probability actions [20]. Thus, AIS adapts the mixture strength, whereas CIS adapts the cap. CIS evaluates BF16 cross-engine mismatch; transfer to FP4 remains untested.

Additive score correction. Score Centering addresses a different object from the sampled-token importance weight [10]. Here the *score* is the parameter-gradient vector $s_\theta(a, h) = \nabla_\theta \log p_\theta(a \mid h)$, not the reward assigned to an answer. Its mean is zero under the learner distribution, but can be nonzero under the actual behavior distribution. In Equation (4), that conditional mean produces an additional term proportional to the conditional mean advantage. Group-centered rewards need not remove it because prompt-level centering does not center the signal at every generated prefix.

Score Centering replaces the score at a prefix with

$$\widetilde{s}_\theta(a, h) = s_\theta(a, h) - \mathbb{E}_{b \sim q(\cdot \mid h)}[s_\theta(b, h)]. \tag{11}$$

With the exact expectation, its mean under q vanishes and the drift term in Equation (4) is removed [10]. The remaining covariance is still measured under q, so this is not full recovery of an on-policy gradient. The reported implementation uses sampler top-k log-probabilities and models the omitted tail using the learner distribution; its default is $k = 128$ [10]. The omitted mass therefore enters through a modeled tail rather than being discarded. The coefficients used to form the correction are detached, and its fidelity depends on that behavior reconstruction.

Figure 9 gives a one-parameter example. Changing the gradient's conditional mean does not require changing the sampler or forcing the learner probabilities to equal it. This separates a correction to the estimator from direct numerical alignment. When combined with importance weighting, the centered object must be the corresponding weighted score; an arbitrary weighted loss with the original unweighted center need not have the intended cancellation [10].

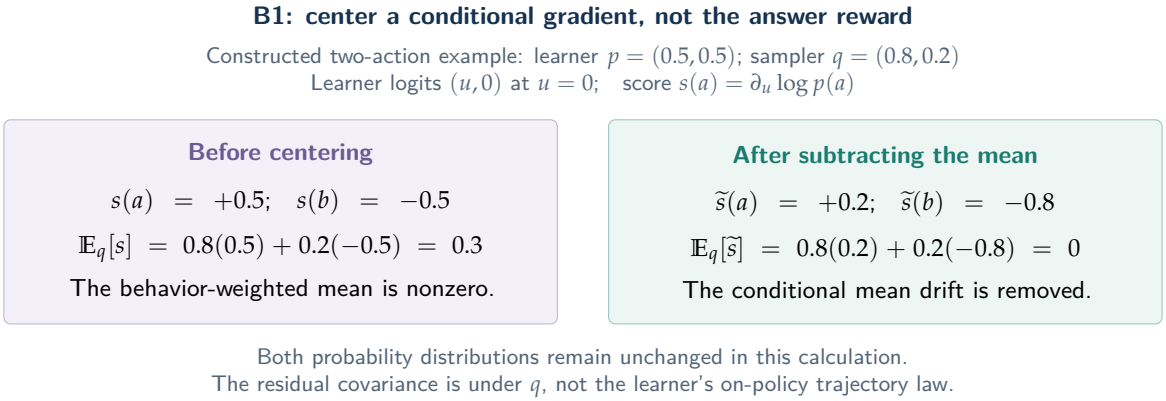


Figure 9: Constructed scalar-logit example of score centering [10]. Sampler probabilities weight the derivatives in Equation (11). Centering changes the conditional gradient mean while leaving both distributions fixed; practical top-k reconstruction adds an approximation.

Baselines and score centering interact differently at token and sequence level [27]. For the sequence-level regularized importance estimators studied there, the group-mean baseline already supplies the centering benefit. At token level, that baseline generally leaves bias under regularized ratios. Centering must match the estimand, weights, and reduction.

TIS, AIS, and CIS need sampled-action probabilities. Score Centering also needs a behavior expectation over actions at each prefix, which sampled-token log probabilities alone do not determine.

5.2. Controlling the Influence of Policy Updates

Update-control methods differ in what they restrict and at what scale. They reshape clipping boundaries, adapt constraints to batch reliability, choose a divergence geometry, select signed contributions, or accept and reject whole synchronized candidates (Table 5).

Restoring or reshaping update constraints. QuRL's Adaptive Clipping Range (ACR) adjusts the permitted update region using proximal and behavior probabilities [5]. It addresses clipping distorted by mismatch already present at collection. UAQ (Section 4.2) addresses a different failure: the quantized sampler may not express the resulting weight change. QuRL therefore acts on both learning an update and transmitting it through quantization.

Table 5: Update-control mechanisms within B2, with their decision signals and aggregation units.

Decision	Signal or constraint	Unit	Representative components
Boundary placement	Mismatch-aware, trust-band, or reference-calibrated clipping.	Token or response.	QuRL ACR; QaRL TBPO; Calibrated Clipping.
Batch adaptation	ESS determines cap and regularization.	Batch statistics, applied through the objective.	P3O.
Constraint geometry	Divergence-based boundary or smooth regularizer.	Token-level probability shifts.	DPPO; DRPO.
Directional influence	Advantage and discrepancy determine retained or corrective contributions.	Tokens and segments within responses.	ACRL; TRIAGE.
Candidate acceptance	Assessment after inference-side synchronization.	Whole candidate policy.	MIPU.

QaRL's TBPO constrains whole responses through negative-sample treatment and a sequence-level trust band [6]. Full-pipeline FP8 instead calibrates clipping against BF16: it matches the lower quantile on negative-advantage tokens, then adjusts the upper boundary to rebalance signed contributions [11]. Periodic reference passes amortize calibration of the update boundary.

Clipping statistics require the advantage sign, reduction, and comparison policy to be specified. An aggregate fraction cannot reveal which useful contributions a boundary removes.

Adapting control to batch reliability. P3O uses normalized effective sample size (ESS) of the batch's policy ratios to adapt a score-weight cap and off-policy regularization [21]. Its FP8-rollout experiment studies numerical mismatch directly, while broader comparisons show dependence on the model and collection setting. AIS adapts an estimator mixture; P3O adjusts update constraints.

Choosing the constraint geometry. DPPO introduces a divergence-based trust region [29]. DRPO retains Binary-TV geometry but replaces hard masking with a smooth regularizer that supplies corrective gradients outside the boundary [22]. DRPO evaluates FP8-rollout-only and end-to-end FP8 MoE settings, extending the available precision evidence for this update geometry.

Controlling disagreement through update direction. ACRL steers disagreement through advantage-guided token reweighting controlled by response-level discrepancy from a reference [9].

TRIAGE connects the advantage sign to the learner–sampler log gap [12]. Using $d_\theta = \log p_\theta - \log q_k$ in this survey's notation, the product $A_i d_{\theta,i,t}$ identifies the sign of a simplified token's own mismatch-energy contribution. Cross-token coupling and optimizer history can change the realized motion, so this is a local directional indicator. Both $A_i > 0, d_\theta > 0$ and $A_i < 0, d_\theta < 0$ are locally amplifying. TRIAGE intervenes selectively on the latter: increasing the probability of a reward-positive response can be legitimate learning even if its gap grows.

The gate first diagnoses 64-position segments of negative-advantage responses from their mean gap and deep negative tail. Within an eligible risky segment, only negative-gap tokens receive an attenuated raw weight $b_{i,t}$. The weighted response loss is normalized by the sum of its weights.

Relative to ordinary response averaging, its effective multiplier is therefore $b_{i,t}/\bar{b}_i$, not simply $b_{i,t}$. Normalization reallocates contributions: for illustrative raw weights $(0.3, 1, 0.3, 1)$, the effective multipliers are approximately $(0.46, 1.54, 0.46, 1.54)$. If every weight is equal, the normalization cancels it. This controls relative influence, not the total gradient norm.

Repair targets positive-advantage responses with sufficiently negative mean gaps in 128-position segments. A one-sided pseudo-Huber penalty raises learner log probabilities. Its derivative bounds the additive coefficient, not the full gradient or every token's gap. All valid tokens in an active segment share that coefficient, including positive-gap tokens. Gating and repair thus address different signed contributions [12]. The tested recipe uses native W4A4 forward on both endpoints and BF16 KV. Applying it to KV4 remains an untested transfer.

Accepting whole updates in the inference policy. MIPU constructs candidates relative to the sampler, then assesses whether a synchronized candidate should become the next inference policy [23]. This separates candidate construction from acceptance after numerical conversion. The practical inference-gap proxy supports acceptance or rollback in the evaluated FP8 runs; a general guarantee of monotonic improvement would require stronger conditions.

Local rules can locate concentrated risk, but their statistics are noisier. Broader aggregation trades localization for reliability. Candidate acceptance tests a further condition: whether a learner-side improvement survives conversion to the inference policy.

5.3. Adapting the Optimization Schedule

Beyond Precision adapts the learning-rate schedule to the evolution of optimization and mismatch [18]. Scheduling changes the scale of successive parameter updates, complementing numerical alignment and sample-level control. Direct evidence under aggressive quantization remains limited. Its value depends on preserving quality within the same budget, since smaller steps can delay progress as well as divergence.

5.4. Compatibility, Bias, and Failure Modes

Combining methods is useful when one addresses an error left by the other. Weight alignment can leave activation error, and a more faithful sampler can still generate off-policy data. QaRL, QuRL, and QUADS test combinations addressing such residual effects [5, 6, 8].

Estimator compatibility depends on weighting, centering, masking, and reduction. Token- and sequence-level regularized estimators can require different centers [27]. Figure 10 distinguishes this estimation target from the contributions selected by update control.

Score Centering removes a conditional score mean; TRIAGE selects contributions using advantage and log-gap signs. Their joint effect remains untested [10, 12].

Composition also creates dependencies. An importance-weighted score needs its corresponding weighted center [10]; successive masks can suppress the same examples, and guidance or reference passes add cost. The combinations in Table 6 have been studied jointly; other combinations cannot inherit those results without checking their estimator and execution assumptions.

Table 6: Studied component combinations, their intervention targets, and the residual effects addressed.

Study	Combined components	Mechanistic connection
QuRL [5]	Update-aware quantization (A2) and adaptive clipping (B2).	Make parameter changes visible to the sampler and reshape the learner's update constraint.
QaRL [6]	Aligned QAT (A1) and TBPO (B2).	Reduce representational disagreement, then constrain problematic response-level updates.
QUADS [8]	Weight QAT (A1) and residual activation compensation (A2).	Weight alignment leaves activation error for a separate numerical component.
KV4-RL [17]	Selective cache protection (A2) with retained TIS.	Improve the data-generating path while holding a bounded conditional correction in the recipe.
TRACE [13]	Guided QAT (A1), routing replay, and token-ratio correction.	Couple rounding outcomes while separately addressing route choices and residual off-policy effects.
Score Centering [10]	Centering composed with TIS or MIS (B1).	Center the corresponding weighted score; reconstruction and regularization determine the remaining bias.

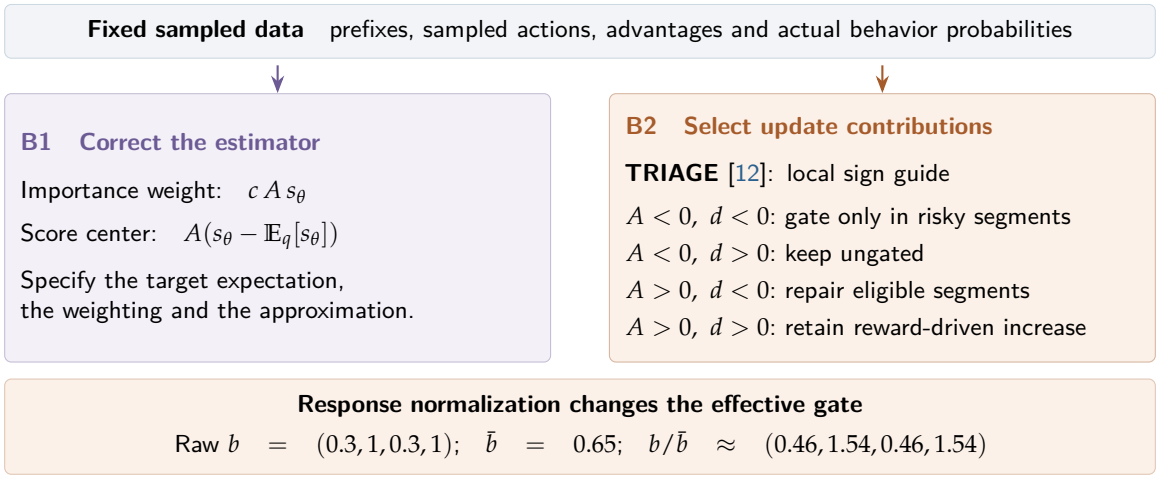


Figure 10: Estimator correction and update control. TRIAGE [12] uses $d = d_\theta$ with segment-level conditions. Repair acts on positive-advantage, negative-mean segments and includes all their valid tokens. Raw weights illustrate normalization, rather than a diagnosed segment; shared parameters limit token-wise predictions.

6. Evidence Synthesis and System Trade-offs

Experiments distinguish agreement from useful learning and rollout speed from total cost. Conclusions depend on the model, execution path, evaluation protocol, and budget.

6.1. Experimental Regimes

A higher-precision learner paired with a quantized sampler exposes differences between representations. Quantizing both sides can still leave different kernels, activations, and updates. KV quantization changes retained attention state; weight and activation quantization affect other computations. Low-rank and full-parameter adaptation have different capacities to accommodate these errors.

AIS evaluates diffusion-based LLaDA alongside autoregressive Qwen models [7]. The Qwen experiments follow the token-level formulation used here; the denoising results require likelihoods defined for their generation process.

Evaluation precision determines which policy is assessed. KV4-RL uses a common BF16 evaluator to compare learned parameters under a fixed execution path [17]. TRACE evaluates its FP4 policy, including the low-precision realization of those parameters [13]. These protocols can yield different quality assessments of the same checkpoint.

Architecture and collection protocol further condition conclusions. MoE execution introduces discrete route choices; cache-heavy long responses expose different runtime bottlenecks from shorter generations; partial collection permits a response to contain tokens sampled under different parameter versions. These differences affect both the mismatch mechanism and the cost of intervention.

Miles adds production-scale agentic system evidence, whereas QATFactory isolates a smaller NVFP4 QARL workload [25, 26]. Native low-precision arithmetic, simulated quantization, and BF16 execution on quantized operands are distinct regimes. In particular, HiFloat4 reports simulated FP4 RL rather than measured native-FP4 training [24].

Table 7 summarizes four evaluated learner and rollout configurations. Appendix B maps coverage across numerical, architectural, and collection regimes (Table 12).

Table 7: Representative learner, rollout, and collection configurations. QAT specifies adaptation; forward, backward, and optimizer precision are separate attributes.

Study	Learner path	Rollout and collection setting
TRACE [13]	Guided fake-quantized forward; BF16 backward.	NVFP4 W4A4 on routed experts and KV4 in softmax attention; other modules BF16. Asynchronous collection.
TRIAGE [12]	Native NVFP4 W4A4 forward.	Native W4A4 forward; BF16 KV in the documented characterization. Synchronous math RL; no reported KV4 experiment.
Score Centering [10]	BF16 learner; distributional reconstruction supplies the correction.	Quantized-sampler stress tests include FP4 KV and INT8 sampler with INT4 KV. Policy-lag tests form a separate setting.
KV4-RL [17]	BF16 learner.	INT4 KV with bounded INT8 protection. Quota-based partial collection; generation and learning alternate. This is a cache-focused experiment.

6.2. Findings on Stability and Learning Quality

Component comparisons can test whether correcting a measured error improves learning. Figure 11 shows the baselines in TRACE and TRIAGE; Table 9 compares their findings with Score Centering and KV4-RL. Appendix E records the diagnostic practices of all nineteen core studies.

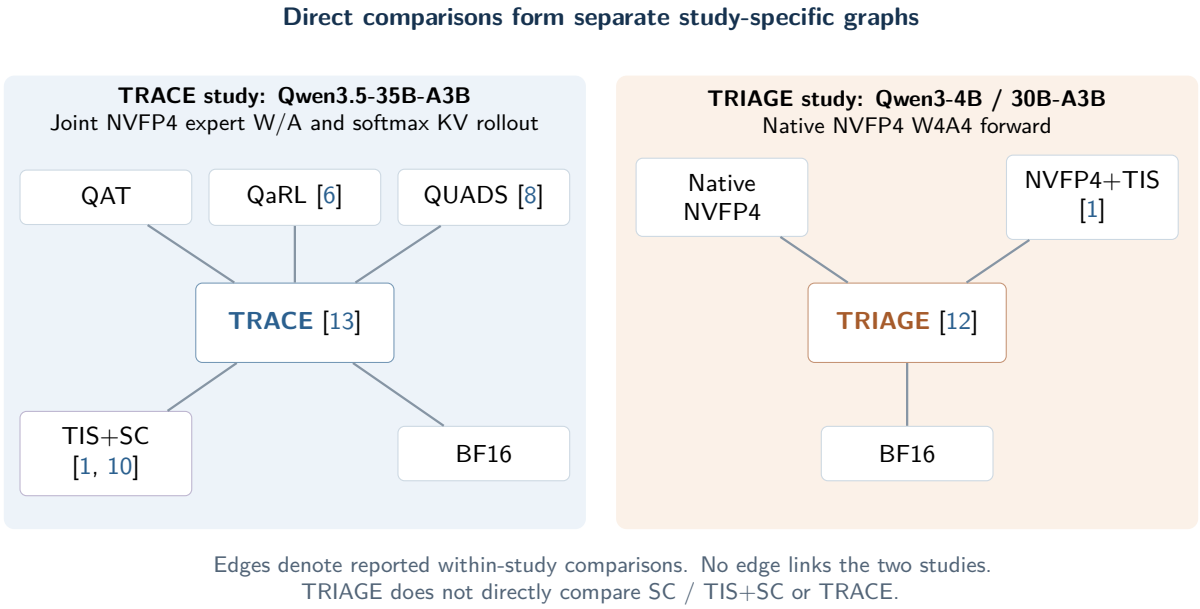


Figure 11: Study-specific comparison graphs for TRACE and TRIAGE [12, 13]. Each BF16 reference belongs to its study's execution setting. Table 9 gives outcomes and checkpoint conditions.

Agreement and policy improvement. Entropy, reward, and probability gaps describe different aspects of a training trajectory (Table 8). Section 3.4 defines mismatch measurements; their joint evolution reveals whether closer agreement accompanies useful learning.

Table 8: Reading learning trajectories. Definitions illustrate common conventions; the source policy and reduction determine the logged quantity.

Quantity	What it measures	What it does not establish
Policy entropy H	$-\sum_a p(a) \log p(a)$ for a specified next-token policy, subsequently aggregated over prefixes.	A lower value need not indicate better learning. A label such as *entropy loss* does not establish that entropy regularization is active.
Mean reward $\bar{R}$	$B^{-1} \sum_i R_i$ over B sampled responses. With strictly binary correctness reward, it is the sampled correctness rate.	It is not the group-normalized advantage, a held-out benchmark score, or an invariant scale across reward functions.
Mean absolute gap G	Magnitude of learner–behavior disagreement on valid sampled tokens; Equation (6).	It removes sign and local concentration; it is neither KL divergence nor proof of estimator fidelity or policy quality.

In TRIAGE's 30B experiment, TIS prevents the aggregate gap from diverging over the measured horizon, yet later reward and downstream scores remain below the full method [12]. Conversely, useful reward-driven updates can increase signed gaps. The gap must therefore be read alongside the contributions retained and the resulting policy quality.

A metric used by a controller needs independent outcome checks. AIS uses a gap to adapt correction, KV4-RL measures cache distortion with conditional KL, and TRIAGE uses signed, localized gaps to design its controls [7, 12, 17]. Reducing the controlled metric alone is insufficient; the intervention must also preserve learning on outcomes it does not directly optimize.

Sustained learning and delayed instability. QuRL observes disagreement after initial stability; ACR and UAQ target clipping and update visibility [5]. AIS adapts the correction mixture, ACRL controls update influence, and Score Centering removes conditional estimator drift [7, 9, 10]. Each changes the policy and subsequent mismatch. P3O's Qwen3-8B FP8 experiment links batch-adaptive control to preserved later performance over the evaluated horizon [21].

TRACE reports increasing discrepancy and later quality loss for conventional FP4 QAT in its joint W/A/KV setting [13]. TRIAGE explicitly leaves substantially longer training horizons unevaluated [12]. These observations distinguish a demonstrated late failure from an unresolved durability question. Neither establishes that every remedy eventually fails. Stable learning under residual mismatch can be a valid outcome; the relevant evidence is continued useful improvement over a stated budget, not disappearance of every probability gap.

Shared computation matters more than nominal symmetry. Jet-RL shares precision flow; QaRL, QUADS, and TRACE couple representations or rounding decisions [3, 6, 8, 13]. In QUADS, asymmetric weight QAT recovers much of the lost performance, and rollout activation compensation adds further gains. Its symmetric-QAT comparison shows that quantizing more learner operands can worsen agreement. HiFloat4's simulated ablations also locate residual error in rollout activations [24]. FP8-RL updates calibration and synchronization as the policy changes; QATFactory compares training in the target representation with quantizing the learned endpoint [4, 26]. Alignment claims thus depend on which operators, weights, scales, or rounding outcomes are actually shared.

Preserving useful updates matters beyond reducing average gaps. The full-pipeline FP8 study links excessive lower-side clipping of negative-advantage tokens to pathological training dynamics; TRIAGE selects interventions using local, directional information [11, 12]. DRPO preserves corrective gradients outside its trust region; MIPU assesses a whole candidate after conversion to the inference policy [22, 23]. These controls act at different locations and stages, which aggregate clipping fractions or mean gaps cannot distinguish. TRIAGE's routing-conditioned MoE analysis also finds that a population-level directional trend need not predict every token's motion. Checkpoint selection further affects the comparison: the full-pipeline FP8 study chooses its main GRPO endpoints by best average performance over 500 steps [11], whereas TRIAGE uses the final scheduled step for stable arms. Similar endpoint scores can summarize different learning trajectories.

TRACE tests guided alignment against QAT and TIS+SC in joint low-precision execution; TRIAGE tests recovery beyond TIS in native W4A4. These different baseline sets and precision regimes preclude a direct TRACE–TRIAGE ranking [12, 13].

Ablations help identify the error that makes a second component useful. QUADS separates weight alignment from activation compensation, QuRL combines update visibility with clipping control, and KV4-RL changes cache fidelity while retaining TIS [5, 8, 17]. These results support the tested combinations; extending them requires identifying the residual error in the new setting.

6.3. Efficiency Gains and Implementation Costs

Computational benefit depends on the complete learning loop. Under serialized execution, iteration time is

$$T_{\text{iter}} = T_{\text{rollout}} + T_{\text{learner}} + T_{\text{sync}} + T_{\text{quant/calib}} + T_{\text{other}}, \tag{12}$$

Table 9: Within-study results with their execution, checkpoint, and comparison boundaries.

Study	Controlled comparison	Reported result	Interpretation and limit
TRACE [13] 35B MoE	Joint NVFP4 W/A/KV rollout; TIS+SC uses cap 2 and top-128 reconstruction.	Four-task mean: TRACE 75.3, TIS+SC 74.1, BF16 74.9.	SC selects its best mean checkpoint through 400 steps. Task-wise gains are mixed; aggregate values are shown without uncertainty intervals.
TRIAGE [12] 30B MoE	BF16, native NVFP4, TIS, and full gating/repair recipe. Stable arms use step 1700.	Five-task mean: TRIAGE 70.96, TIS 63.18, BF16 72.41.	Recovery relative to TIS in native W4A4; SC/TIS+SC and KV4 are outside the comparison.
Score Centering [10] 30B MoE	Correction rules share the objective; quantization and lag are tested separately.	With FP4 KV, SC and TIS remain stable; stronger INT8/INT4 stress separates them further.	Quantization curves report training accuracy. Shared-objective controls are not full reproductions of every baseline recipe.
KV4-RL [17] 8B dense	Cache precision varies with TIS retained; all learned policies are evaluated in BF16.	At 400 updates, six-task mean: 52.8 versus BF16's 52.4; cumulative full-iteration speedup 1.27×.	Evaluation-seed variation is not independent training-run variation; this is not a joint W4A4/KV4 comparison.

with synchronization and quantization/calibration accounted for separately. Accelerating one phase increases the relative cost of the others. Overlapped execution instead depends on the critical path, for which the additive model in Equation (12) does not apply.

For fixed workload and remaining phases, rollout fraction f, rollout speedup s, and added work hT_0 give $T/T_0 = (1-f) + f/s + h$ (Figure 12). Overlap, response-length changes, or altered concurrency require a different model.

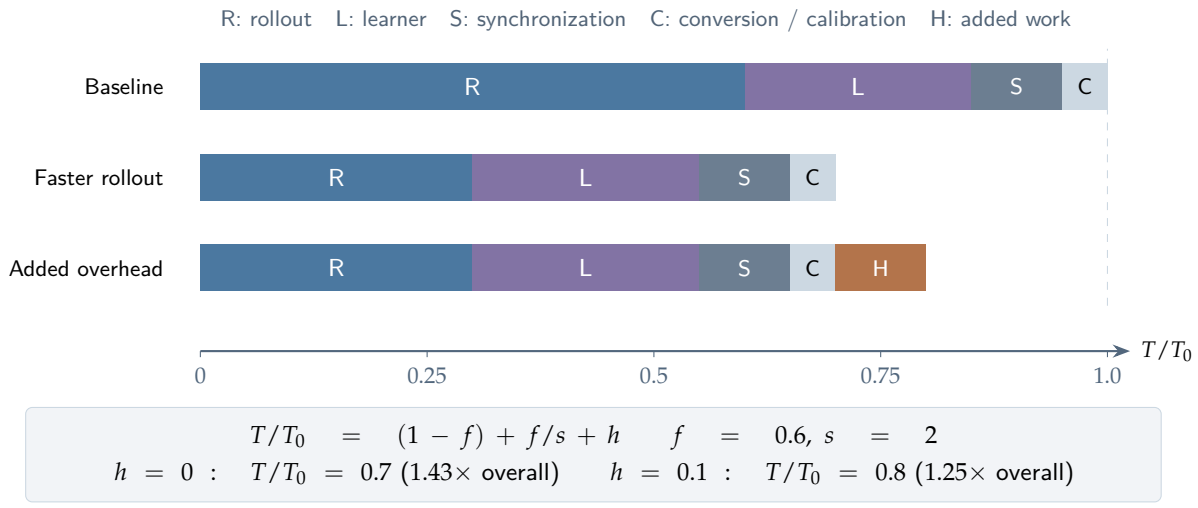


Figure 12: Serialized timing with a faster rollout phase and added overhead. Doubling rollout speed reduces iteration time from T_0 to $0.7T_0$ when rollout accounts for 60% of the baseline. Added work of $0.1T_0$ reduces the overall speedup from 1.43× to 1.25×. Constructed illustration under serialized execution.

Each intervention changes a different part of this cost. FP8-RL illustrates the work needed for scale estimation and numerical conversion [4]. Reference calibration adds learner computation; guided rounding adds storage, transport, and state matching; selective precision adds work in the protected region. Table 10 relates these dependencies to the information each method needs.

Table 10: Information and execution dependencies that determine implementation cost.

Approach	Information or execution dependency	Consequence for implementation
TIS / AIS / CIS	Behavior probabilities and learner/proximal probabilities	Stored probabilities must include the sampling transformations.
Score Centering	A behavior-weighted score expectation, exact or approximated	Exact evaluation requires distributional information; reconstruction introduces approximation.
Aligned QAT / shared precision	Matching quantization and conversion rules across endpoints	Precision exceptions, kernels, and weight export form part of the configuration.
Guided rounding	Realized rollout-side quantization information	Guidance requires storage, transport, and matching to learner states.
Calibrated Clipping [11]	Higher-precision reference ratios at calibration points	Reference passes add training computation, amortized across calibration intervals.
Batch-adaptive control [21]	Policy-ratio statistics aggregated over the batch	Reduction rules and the sampled batch determine the reliability estimate.
Inference-policy acceptance [23]	Assessment of the synchronized candidate	Candidate evaluation and possible rollback add work beyond learner updates.
Selective KV precision	Low-bit cache execution with protected positions	Protected positions add work whose share depends on the context workload.

P3O requires batch-level ratio statistics, while MIPU's acceptance step adds inference-side assessment and possible rollback [21, 23]. Miles and QATFactory emphasize conversion and inference-ready weight transfer as part of the execution contract [25, 26]. TBIK's coordinated reductions can carry a kernel-performance cost [28]. Rollout-ResQ's sparse correction is designed for efficient hardware execution, but its simulated experiments do not measure a native FP4 speedup [24].

The useful quantization target depends on the workload as well as the format. QUADS targets native W4A4 expert computation, whereas KV4-RL studies how sustained concurrency and long contexts increase the value of reducing KV processing [8, 17]. Their settings motivate different numerical targets; a bit-width comparison alone does not identify the dominant cost.

Throughput depends on response length and concurrency. Shorter responses can reduce generation time without improving per-token execution; longer responses can increase work despite faster kernels. Memory savings can raise concurrency and change the kernel workload. PagedAttention illustrates the effects of cache management and scheduling on serving throughput [32]; RL efficiency additionally depends on the resulting learning trajectory.

KV4-RL reports 1.80× cumulative rollout speedup and 1.27× cumulative full-iteration speedup over BF16 rollout across 400 Qwen3-8B-Base iterations [17]. The difference reflects the cost of the remaining phases. Its common-BF16 evaluation separately compares learned-policy quality, with both results tied to the evaluated collection workload.

Quality at a fixed budget and cost to a specified quality level account for changes in learning as well as execution. Extra learner passes, changed response lengths, and the number of updates needed all enter that comparison. In overlapped systems, guidance traffic competes for bandwidth, so its isolated overhead can differ from its critical-path cost.

6.4. Evidence Limits and Coverage Gaps

Strong evidence isolates a mechanism within its execution setting. Mathematical reasoning is common; interactive tasks and hardware or kernel transfer have fewer controlled comparisons. Native arithmetic, quantization simulation, and BF16 execution on quantized values remain distinct.

Learning comparisons need a training horizon, budget, checkpoint rule, and uncertainty unit alongside the metric definition in Section 3.4. Best-checkpoint scores can hide later deterioration. Repeated decoding measures evaluation variation; independent RL runs expose training variation. Smoothing alone quantifies neither.

Separate W4A4 and KV4 studies do not establish their joint behavior; asynchronous demonstrations do not isolate every precision–lag interaction. Scheduling needs direct low-bit validation, while diffusion needs generation-specific likelihoods before the autoregressive analysis can transfer.

7. Open Problems

Open questions concern sustained learning under mismatch, the composition and cost of remedies, stateful behavior, and transfer across execution settings.

7.1. Sustaining Learning over Extended Training

A predictive diagnostic should detect lost learning before reward deteriorates. Ratio tails, conditional score drift, clipping errors, and segment concentration point to different mechanisms. Prediction must distinguish harmful mismatch from legitimate policy movement and from apparent stability obtained by discarding difficult data. Paired probes, fixed-batch audits, and held-out trajectories connect execution differences to update effects and learning consequences.

Sustained mitigation requires a stronger test than delaying the first unstable update. Longer continuations should determine whether correction remains effective as the policy, activation statistics, and sampled states evolve. Adaptive recalibration, guidance allocation, or update control are possible responses; their adaptation cost and retained learning signal need joint assessment. The goal is useful learning under changing numerical conditions, without requiring every residual gap to vanish. Comparisons across extended budgets should distinguish preserved improvement, postponed deterioration, and stagnation caused by increasingly restrictive intervention.

ACRL identifies a specific durability question: its reference discrepancy is fixed at initialization, and substantially longer training may require a moving baseline [9]. Score Centering notes that its severe-mismatch, short-sequence experiments proxy longer training under milder mismatch [10]. Establishing when such stress tests predict extended-run behavior would make them more informative without treating them as substitutes for that evidence.

7.2. Composing Numerical and Learning Interventions

A component's benefit depends on the error left by the rest of the system. Weight alignment can leave activation error, and estimator correction can change the need for restrictive update control. Score Centering identifies a remaining reward–score covariance under the sampler rather than the learner, motivating its composition with importance sampling under severe staleness [10]. Beyond the combinations in Table 6, guided rounding with score centering and cache protection with directional control require direct study. Ablations must identify the error removed, useful contributions retained, and added cost, distinguishing a joint benefit from retuning or a dominant component.

7.3. Reducing Mitigation Cost and Complexity

TRACE already reduces guidance storage by recording low code bits and scales for selected layers [13]. Further compression raises a question: how much rollout-side information is sufficient to retain the learning benefit? Adaptive selection of layers, tokens, or training phases could reduce metadata while preserving the rounding decisions that matter most for the update. The relevant cost includes storage, transport, reconstruction, and synchronization.

TRIAGE derives its controls from directional analysis, combining segment tests, token gates, response normalization, and repair rules. Its future directions include repair adapted to mismatch magnitude, locality, and persistence [12]. A unified objective or compact adaptive controller could reduce manual configuration. The objective remains to preserve useful update contributions, since minimizing a measured gap can suppress legitimate learning. Evaluation should include tuning effort and controller overhead, with comparable tuning budgets across methods.

Decision granularity offers another route to lower cost. QaRL proposes token-level approximations to improve utilization of its sequence-level objective, while MIPU identifies more efficient synchronized-candidate assessment as an open design choice [6, 23]. Such approximations must retain the information needed for a reliable update or acceptance decision.

7.4. Precision, Staleness, and Long-Horizon Interaction

TRIAGE leaves asynchronous validation open, while KV4-RL identifies disaggregated systems, additional attention architectures, and multi-turn workloads as extensions of its evaluated setting [12, 17]. These settings change both the discrepancy and the state needed to interpret it.

A checkpoint need not identify the behavior policy. Responses can cross synchronization boundaries, and retained KV entries encode earlier computations. Applying the separation in Equation (2) therefore requires the relevant history. What is the smallest sufficient behavior record: token probabilities, version identifiers, cache provenance, or additional execution state?

Early numerical perturbations also change the prefixes visited later, beyond the conditional correction at an observed token. Precision allocation across layers, positions, and training phases should therefore follow learning benefit rather than tensor error alone. Multi-turn environments extend this question to tool observations and state transitions.

7.5. Generalization and Comparable Evidence

Transfer requires actual decoding probabilities for reweighting, distributional information for score reconstruction, and paired states for rounding guidance. An engine or synchronization change can break these dependencies at the same format.

Component comparisons need a shared execution path and base objective. System comparisons must preserve each method's essential design under matched resources. Quality at a fixed budget and cost to a predeclared target, including failure to reach it, relate learning progress to runtime.

AIS leaves the exploratory role of quantization noise unresolved [7]. Controlled ablations should distinguish exploration, smoothing, and altered update weighting.

8. Conclusion

Low-precision rollout changes both the experience used for RL and the updates learned from it. Numerical design addresses the computations that produce disagreement; estimator correction and update control address its effects on learning. These approaches can be combined when their information requirements and residual errors are understood.

The reviewed results separate numerical agreement from useful learning. A smaller gap can coexist with weaker policy improvement, and faster generation need not yield a proportional reduction in training cost. Stability is supported over the tested training horizon; extended runs must distinguish sustained learning from postponed deterioration. Progress requires interpretable diagnostics, efficient mitigation, and quality–cost comparisons across training budgets.

A. Surveyed Papers and Section Mapping

Table 11 maps the twenty-nine focal studies to regimes, components, and discussion locations. Years mark first public appearance; bibliography entries may cite later publications. Parentheses give additional discussion locations. Appendix B defines contribution roles.

Table 11: Surveyed papers: numerical regimes, method components, and section mapping. Conference and preprint versions count as one contribution.

Work / first year	Numerical regime	Component(s) and contribution	Discussion
Core method and system studies (19)			
FlashRL / TIS [1] 2025	Higher-precision learner; quantized rollout	**B1**: Recorded behavior probabilities and truncated correction.	**5.1** (1.1; 2.1)
Jet-RL [3] 2026	Unified FP8 learner and rollout paths	**A1; A2**: Unified FP8 precision flow.	**4.1** (6.2)
FP8-RL [4] 2026	W8A8 rollout; FP8 attention / KV; FP8 learner explored in v2	**A2; system**: W8A8 rollout, FP8 attention/KV, and stack integration.	**4.2** (5.1; 6.2; 6.3)
QuRL [5] 2026	INT8 / FP8 rollout	**B2; A2**: Adaptive clipping and update-aware quantization.	**5.2** (3.1; 4.2; 5.4; 6.2)
QaRL [6] 2026	Quantized MoE rollout; aligned learner QAT	**A1; B2**: Rollout-aligned QAT and trust-band updates.	**4.1** (5.2; 5.4; 6.2; 7.3)
P3O / ESS [21] 2026	BF16 learner / FP8 rollout; dense reasoning models	**B2**: Batch-adaptive ESS cap and regularization.	**5.2** (6.2; 6.3)
AIS [7] 2026	BF16 learner / FP8 rollout; autoregressive and diffusion models	**B1**: Adaptive importance-weighted estimator mixture.	**5.1** (6.1; 6.2; 7.5)
DRPO [22] 2026	BF16, FP8 rollout-only, and FP8 end-to-end MoE settings	**B2**: Smooth corrective divergence regularization.	**5.2** (6.2)
MIPU [23] 2026	BF16 learner / FP8 rollout; Qwen3-1.7B and 4B	**B2; formulation**: Inference-policy candidate construction and acceptance.	**5.2** (2.1; 6.2; 6.3; 7.3)
QUADS [8] 2026	NVFP4 MoE rollout; learner weight QAT	**A1; A2**: NVFP4 MoE weight alignment and activation compensation.	**4.1** (4.2; 5.4; 6.2)
ACRL [9] 2026	FP8 rollout; discrepancy-dependent updates	**B2**: Discrepancy-dependent update control.	**5.2** (3.3; 6.2; 7.1)
HiFloat4 / Rollout-ResQ [24] 2026	Simulated end-to-end HiF4 / MXFP4; rollout residual correction	**A2**: Sparse residual correction for FP4 rollout activations.	**4.2** (3.1; 6.2; 6.3)
Miles v0.1 [25] 2026	FP8 / MXFP8 / NVFP4 RL recipes; precision exceptions	**A1; A2; system**: Shared quantization, synchronization, and precision contracts.	**4.1** (4.2; 6.1; 6.3)
Score Centering [10] 2026	BF16 learner; FP4/INT4 KV stress and separate lag tests	**B1**: Additive behavior-weighted score correction.	**5.1** (2.2; 3.2; 5.4; 6.2; 7.1; 7.2)
Full Pipeline FP8 RL [11] 2026	FP8 learner and rollout; calibration against BF16	**B2; system**: FP8 learner/rollout and calibrated clipping.	**5.2** (3.2; 6.2; 6.3)

Continued on next page

Table 11 continued: Surveyed papers

Work / first year	Numerical regime	Component(s) and contribution	Discussion
QATFactory / QARL [26] 2026	Native NVFP4 rollout; simulated-quantization BF16 training	**A1; system**: Deployment-aligned QARL and inference-ready weight synchronization.	**4.1** (6.2; 6.3)
TRIAGE [12] 2026	Native W4A4 forward; documented BF16 KV; synchronous RL	**B2**: Direction-aware control for native NVFP4.	**5.2** (3.3; 6.2; 7.3; 7.4)
TRACE [13] 2026	NVFP4 expert W4A4 + softmax KV4; guided QAT, BF16 backward	**A1**: Rollout-guided FP4 rounding for MoE.	**4.1** (3.1; 6.2; 7.3)
KV4-RL [17] 2026	BF16 learner; INT4 KV with bounded INT8 protection	**A2; system**: INT4 KV with selective INT8 protection.	**4.2** (5.1; 6.2; 6.3; 7.4)
Supporting formulation, theory, and general TIM studies (9)			
R3 [15] 2025	MoE routing; general execution mismatch	**Support; A1**: MoE routing alignment.	**3.1** (4.1)
FP16-Mismatch [16] 2025	BF16 / FP16 numerical comparison	**Support; A2**: BF16/FP16 precision-selection evidence.	**3.1**
TBIK / Deterministic Inference [28] 2025	BF16 / FP32; matched reduction order across TP sizes	**Support; A1**: Cross-TP deterministic kernels as an alignment reference.	**3.1** (4.1; 6.3)
MiniRL [14] 2025	Hybrid-engine RL; includes FP8-rollout experiments	**Support; B1/B2**: Policy roles and mismatch-aware formulation; FP8 experiments.	**2.1** (1.2; 5.1)
Beyond Precision [18] 2026	General TIM; optimization scheduling	**Support; B3**: Optimization schedule under general TIM.	**5.3** (3.3)
DPPO [29] 2026	General LLM trust-region and cross-engine mismatch evidence	**Support; B2**: Divergence-based trust regions under general TIM.	**5.2** (3.2)
VeXact / Diagnosing TIM [19] 2026	Matched-execution diagnostic reference	**Diagnostic**: Zero-mismatch diagnostic reference.	**3.4**
CIS [20] 2026	BF16 cross-engine mismatch	**Support; B1**: Confidence-dependent correction under BF16 cross-engine mismatch.	**5.1** (3.2)
Baselines and Score Centering [27] 2026	Sequence- and token-level regularized importance sampling	**Support; B1**: Granularity-dependent roles of baselines and score centering.	**5.1** (5.4)
Exploration boundary case (1)			
QeRL [2] 2025	NVFP4 with LoRA and adaptive noise	**Boundary**: NVFP4 with LoRA and adaptive noise; exploration setting.	**Box 1**

B. Source Selection and Version Handling

Literature identification. We identified twenty-nine contributions on quantized rollout, low-precision RL, and training–rollout mismatch through targeted arXiv metadata searches, primary papers and official publication records, and backward citation tracing.

Inclusion and exclusion. Focal studies contribute a direct quantized-rollout or low-precision RL intervention, a mechanism explaining that setting, or an exploration method in which quantization changes the sampling distribution. General quantization and RL background is cited selectively. Papers devoted only to low-precision pretraining, unrelated generation modalities, or alternative rollout acceleration do not become focal entries solely because they use the same precision format.

Versions and names. The catalog separates first-publication dates, venues, and reviewed versions. QeRL, QuRL, and QaRL use formal publication records. Aliases, conference/preprint versions, and presentation changes count once. Version-unspecified arXiv links remain distinct from pinned reviewed sources because revisions can change the supported claims.

Attribution of evidence. Method claims and observations are attributed to primary sources. The likelihood, drift, and clipping identities explain mechanisms under the stated assumptions; they are distinct from experimental findings. Figures and tables are original syntheses, and constructed examples are labeled separately from published measurements. The companion evidence collection links observations to reviewed sources.

Contribution roles and empirical scope. Core, supporting, and boundary roles describe relevance to the review, independently of experimental quality. Experimental settings are recorded separately. Empirical results are taken from the cited studies and have not been independently reproduced. Training-run replication, negative results, and cross-hardware reproduction were not systematically extracted; versioned records identify the source for each reported observation.

Table 12 summarizes the reviewed settings and contribution roles.

Table 12: Coverage across independent setting axes. Joint regimes require direct evaluation.

Dimension	Represented in the focal collection	Boundary of the synthesis
Intervention	A1/A2 numerical design; B1/B2 learning rules; complementary scheduling.	Direct low-bit evidence is thinner for B3 than for the other classes.
Numerical interface	Weight/activation quantization, KV storage, scales, rounding, routing, and synchronization.	An interface-level result does not establish full-network agreement.
Precision	FP8, FP4/NVFP4, INT8/INT4; BF16/FP16 comparisons provide context.	Format labels omit scale granularity, precision exceptions, and native versus simulated arithmetic.
Model and adaptation	Dense and MoE models; low-rank and full-parameter updates appear in different studies.	Architecture and adaptation are separate axes; cross-regime transfer is not assumed.
Collection	Snapshot-based hybrid execution, policy lag, and quota-based partial collection.	Stateful provenance and fully overlapped execution require additional behavior and timing semantics.
Learning and generation	PPO/GRPO-style autoregressive RL; AIS also studies diffusion generation.	This survey's likelihood equations are autoregressive; denoising requires its own formulation.
Contribution role	Nineteen core studies, nine supporting studies, and one exploration boundary.	Role identifies relevance to the argument, independently of experimental strength.

C. Evidence, Assumptions, and Transfer

The behavior law depends on parameter versions, numerical execution, decoding, and retained state. Learner, proximal, and reference policies have separate roles in the loss. Execution changes can invalidate a correction's assumptions without changing the precision.

Conditional correction leaves prefix selection unchanged; truncation adds bias; alignment leaves unmatched operations; reconstructed expectations remain approximate. Transfer requires these residuals and the estimator's assumptions to be reassessed.

Conditional and complete-response correction. Equation (3) corrects actions at a fixed prefix. A response-level expectation also requires correction of how frequently that prefix is reached.

For comparison, the full-response likelihood ratio is

$$W_\theta(y \mid x) = \frac{P_\theta(y \mid x)}{Q(y \mid x)} = \prod_{t=1}^{T} \frac{p_\theta(y_t \mid h_t)}{q_{k(t)}(y_t \mid h_t)}. \tag{13}$$

Here P_θ and Q are response laws under a common stopping convention, including end-of-sequence decisions when applicable. Denominator factors must be actual conditional probabilities. Unobserved execution randomness must be marginalized or included through an extended likelihood over the corresponding execution events.

For a fixed behavior law and a parameter-independent reward R, the usual likelihood-ratio identity gives

$$\nabla_\theta \mathbb{E}_{P_\theta}[R] = \mathbb{E}_Q\left[W_\theta R \sum_{t=1}^{T} s_\theta(y_t, h_t)\right] \tag{14}$$

under support, integrability, and differentiation assumptions. The product illustrates why exact response-level correction can have high variance; multiplying only the current token ratio into an arbitrary sampled advantage is a different estimator. Nor does Equation (14) directly justify reusing group-normalized advantages computed under Q. Score Centering explicitly distinguishes sequence-level importance sampling from practical token-level corrections [10].

Figure 13 illustrates the effect of unequal prefix masses.

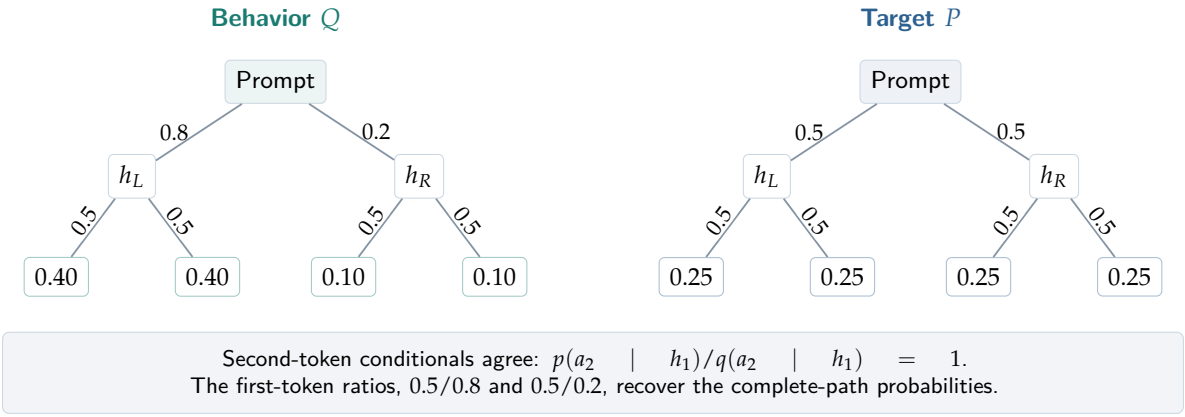


Figure 13: Conditional and response-level correction in a two-step probability tree. Leaf values are complete-response probabilities. Equal second-token conditionals coexist with different prefix masses; the product ratio restores the four target probabilities of 0.25. Constructed two-step example.

D. Terminology

Table 13: Terminology and component abbreviations used in the text and figures.

Term	Meaning
TIM	Training–inference mismatch; the survey emphasizes the learner–rollout interface.
W / A / KV	Weights, activations, and key–value cache; distinct numerical targets.
MoE / LoRA	Mixture-of-experts architecture / low-rank adaptation; architecture and adaptation are separate dimensions.
FP8 / FP4 / NVFP4	Floating-point format families with eight or four bits; NVFP4 is a particular four-bit representation. Scaling, accumulation, and exceptions also determine execution.
INT8 / INT4	Integer quantization at eight or four bits, with scales and execution semantics specified separately.
QAT	Quantization-aware training: the learner forward path models a quantized representation; this need not reproduce native kernel arithmetic.
TIS / MIS	Truncated / masked importance sampling; bounded or discarded corrections alter the estimator.
AIS / CIS	Adaptive / calibrated importance sampling: estimator-mixture adaptation and confidence-dependent truncation, respectively.
ACR / UAQ	QuRL's Adaptive Clipping Range / Update-Aware Quantization; B2 update control and A2 update visibility.
TBPO / RAC	QaRL's Trust-Band Policy Optimization / QUADS's Residual Activation Compensation; distinct objective and numerical components.
PPO / GRPO	Proximal Policy Optimization / Group Relative Policy Optimization. Their loss roles require behavior and proximal policies to be distinguished.
ESS / P3O	Effective sample size / Policy-on Policy-off Policy Optimization; batch-ratio reliability controls update influence and regularization.
DPPO / DRPO	Divergence Proximal / Divergence Regularized Policy Optimization; divergence-based masking versus smooth corrective regularization.
MIPI / MIPU	Monotonic Inference Policy Improvement / Update; inference-policy objective and practical candidate construction/acceptance.
Rollout-ResQ	Sparse residual correction of rollout activation quantization; the reviewed HiFloat4 experiments simulate FP4.
TBIK	Tree-Based Invariant Kernels; matched reduction order across tensor-parallel sizes.
Partial rollout	Collection in which a response can span collection boundaries; it does not by itself imply concurrent generation and optimization.
Cache provenance	Parameter versions and numerical execution paths that produced retained cache entries.
Behavior / proximal / reference	Actual sampling law / update-ratio anchor / KL-regularization target; see Table 1.

E. Reported Mismatch Measurements

Table 14 compares policy distances, control variables, local numerical probes, and learning outcomes across all nineteen core studies. Definitions follow each reviewed source; unspecified conventions are identified, and the companion repository links the complete records.

Table 14: Selected mismatch measurements and comparison conditions across the nineteen core studies. Source locations refer to the reviewed versions.

Study	Reported observable and location	Comparison boundary
FlashRL / TIS [1]	Cross-engine KL (Fig. 3); TIS uses sampled-action ratios.	The plotted KL direction and reduction are not specified in the caption.
Jet-RL [3]	Length- and task-conditioned learning curves (§ 3.2).	Outcome evidence; these curves do not isolate a numerical policy distance.
FP8-RL [4]	Rollout-to-training mismatch KL (§ 2.2.1; Fig. 12).	Direction is explicit; estimator and reduction require further implementation detail.
QuRL [5]	Behavior-to-proximal KL; maximum proximal/behavior ratio (Fig. 3).	Average discrepancy and rare large weights are distinct; neither is the reference KL penalty.
QaRL [6]	Proximal-ratio and mismatch-weight distributions (Fig. 4); response trust bands.	Keep the two ratios separate; geometric-mean response ratios differ from likelihood products.
P3O / ESS [21]	Valid-token normalized ESS, using current/behavior ratios (Eq. 11).	Measures concentration; includes policy change and does not identify numerical error alone.
AIS [7]	Mean absolute log gap; capped-weight ESS; advantage-weight variance amplification (§ 3.1).	These govern distinct gates; capped and raw ESS are different observables.
DRPO [22]	Sampled-action Binary-TV geometry; learning and entropy trajectories (§ 3; App. D.4).	The constraint is not full-vocabulary TV or, by itself, an isolated TIM measurement.
MIPU [23]	Sampled-token mismatch K3; inference-gap proxy and rollback rate (§ 5).	KL estimation and candidate acceptance assess different stages of an update.
QUADS [8]	Maximum log gap; layer-wise MoE L2 discrepancy (Figs. 6–7).	Local tensor error and policy-level extremes have different scales and comparison populations.
ACRL [9]	Absolute probability gap, response/group averaged relative to baseline X (Eqs. 8–12).	Distinct from log gaps; the baseline-relative controller does not define a universal tolerance.
HiFloat4 / Rollout-ResQ [24]	Residual sparsification MSE/RMSE and precision ablations (Fig. 4; § 5).	Tensor reconstruction error should not be relabeled a learner–sampler policy distance.
Miles v0.1 [25]	Same-token log-probability checks; reference-run KL; exact-mode zero difference (§ 3.1; § 5.3; Fig. 5).	Different modes use different comparisons; exact sampled-token scores do not establish full-distribution equality.
Score Centering [10]	Conditional score-mean analysis; controlled learning curves under noise, quantization, and lag (§§ 3–5).	Distinguish the analytical drift term from logged measurements and deliberately amplified stress.

Continued on next page

Table 14 continued

Study	Reported observable and location	Comparison boundary
Full Pipeline FP8 RL [11]	Probability/ratio NMAE against BF16 shadows; sign-separated over-clipping (§ 3).	Counterfactual branch errors differ from ordinary clipping rates and fixed-snapshot TIM.
QATFactory / QARL [26]	QARL learning curves and exported-policy quality (§ 4.6).	Held-out teacher KL elsewhere in the paper belongs to QAD, not an online RL TIM measurement.
TRIAGE [12]	Mean absolute gap, signed tails, directional masses, and localization (§ 3; App. B).	30B characterization is routing-conditioned; its raw magnitude is not directly comparable with ordinary 4B gaps.
TRACE [13]	Log-gap maxima/minima; relative excess train–rollout activation MSE (Figs. 4, 11).	Extremes differ from means; excess MSE uses BF16 cross-path MSE as its denominator.
KV4-RL [17]	Shared-prefix full-distribution BF16-to-quantized KL (Eq. 5.2; App. B.5).	Same checkpoint and pre-decoding probabilities isolate conditional KV distortion; trajectory shift remains outside the metric.

Measurement definitions and reproducibility. The studies differ in execution controls, reduction rules, and uncertainty units. Table 15 organizes these choices into the context needed to interpret and reproduce a reported measurement.

Table 15: Execution controls, statistical reductions, and uncertainty units used in mismatch diagnostics.

Measurement choice	Source practice or example	Required interpretation context
Execution-only comparison	KV4-RL fixes checkpoint and BF16 prefixes for full-distribution KL [17].	Prefix source; raw versus decoded probabilities; routes and cache state; KL direction.
Update-time comparison	TRIAGE replays an identical batch before/after an update with generation log-probabilities held fixed [12].	Learner versions; pre/post stage; fixed advantages and masks; route replay.
Collection-time record	CIS logs generation scores, start-of-update learner scores and rollout versions [20].	Decode versus prefill rescoring; version lag; stored numeric precision and sample selection.
Batch reliability	P3O aggregates raw-ratio moments; AIS uses truncated weights for its ESS gate [7, 21].	Weight definition, cap, valid-token count, and cross-rank reduction.
Decision disagreement	Full-pipeline FP8 compares clipping decisions with BF16 shadow ratios [11].	Reference path; advantage sign; boundary; ordinary versus counterfactual clipping.
Uncertainty and time axis	KV4-RL uses response-cluster bootstrap intervals for its paired fidelity probe [17].	Independent unit: token, response, evaluation seed, or training run; updates, sampled tokens, or elapsed time.

Policy pairs and paired execution. Learner–sampler, current–proximal, and learner–reference KL concern behavior disagreement, policy movement, and regularization. An *actor KL* label needs

its policy pair, direction, and estimator. QATFactory's teacher–student KL evaluates QAD fidelity, separately from online QARL mismatch [26].

To isolate an update's motion, replay the same prefixes before and after the update with the generation scores held fixed, as in TRIAGE's directional audit [12]. To isolate numerical execution, also match the sampling-snapshot parameters and specify kernels, routes, and cache state. A current-learner/old-behavior comparison otherwise combines execution differences and lag.

Measurement population and aggregation. Token averaging weights responses by length; response averaging gives them equal weight. For lengths 2 and 8 with constant absolute gaps 1 and 0.1, the means are 0.28 and 0.55. Global sums and counts define the token mean; P3O likewise reduces ESS moments across workers [21].

Selection can lower a diagnostic without improving agreement on the original batch. Interpretation therefore requires both a fixed valid-token population and the intervention-eligible subset, together with its occupancy and coefficient- or advantage-weighted mass. TRIAGE's separate marginal statistics, gradient-bearing occupancy, and directional masses make this distinction explicit [12]. Raw and capped ESS similarly need the weight definition and cap.

Numerical evaluation. Stored log-probability precision can impose a measurement floor. Saturation and clamping affect log-odds and binary divergences near probability one, as CIS demonstrates in a masking comparison [20]. Logit comparisons additionally require a shared offset convention, since adding the same constant to every vocabulary logit leaves all token probabilities unchanged.

Linking diagnostics to learning outcomes. An informative evaluation links the central gap and its tails to the targeted estimator or update effect, then to held-out quality and total cost. The mechanism determines the additional observable: paired activation error for rounding alignment, weight moments for estimation, or sign-conditioned branch disagreement for clipping calibration.

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